

Bushido Coda

The blade does not lie. Only the hand holding it.

Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Bearing Teeth

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I: Teeth

She said his name wrong. Three times, and Kyle didn't correct her. The apartment smelled like camphor and fear-sweat and something frying in old oil three doors down, the smell coming through the airshaft because the airshaft was the only thing this building had that worked. Her husband sat in the corner with his jaw wired into a shape that wasn't a jaw anymore. He breathed through his nose like a man learning a new language. She pressed the credits into Kyle's hand — a physical transfer, warm chip, slightly damp. He felt what she'd paid. He felt what she hadn't kept.

He took the job at half rate. He told himself it was the jaw. The jaw, wired shut, a man reduced to breathing and waiting. He didn't think about the girl standing in the hallway behind the curtain, watching him the way children watch things they've already decided to memorize.

The building was the kind that pretended not to be a building. A welded conversion between two towers, slotted in twelve stories above ground level and forgotten by the corporation property registry sometime in the 2190s. Kyle had ridden the freight elevator up because the resident elevator did not exist anymore. Looking out the apartment's one window: the canyon between the towers, the rain coming straight down in the cold pillar of air between two structures that had not been designed to leave a gap and had been forced to leave one anyway. A VTOL crossed the gap forty stories up, running lights amber, moving toward something on the south face. Some board director was late to dinner. Some kid was getting their first cyberware. Kyle filed the running lights and didn't look up again.



The motorcycle was three blocks east, parked under an overhang that did most of the work of keeping it dry. Matte black, unbranded, plate magnetized to the underside of the rear cowl. The kind of bike that disappears into the visual noise of any GLMZ block; the kind that's there when you get back because you didn't make it interesting enough for anyone to steal.

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He rode south to the Gray Zone's eastern strut. The route was twenty-two minutes of switchbacks down through tiers the architecture stopped pretending about somewhere around the fortieth floor. By the time he was at the bottom of the strut the rain was warmer and the buildings overhead had closed the sky to a strip. He didn't think about that either. He thought about the jaw. He thought about the camphor smell. He thought about what half-rate meant when half-rate had been pressed warm and damp into a stranger's hand.

He parked the bike a block out and walked the rest. Four men on the loading dock would not be expecting him; six would not be expecting him either. Surprise was free. Surprise was always free. The street's working theory on surprise was that you had to spend something to get it, and the street was wrong about a lot of things, but it was specifically wrong about that.



The loading dock sat at the bottom of the Gray Zone's eastern strut, where the architecture stopped pretending to be architecture and became what it actually was: welded industrial grief. Kyle came in through the front. No hood. No approach angle. He walked in through the front because he wanted the moment — that specific, clarifying moment when six men who have spent weeks feeling like weather look up and see something worse than weather standing in their doorway.

He is six feet of nothing. That's the first thing. A swimmer's build stripped past lean into something the body shouldn't sustain. His cheekbones throw shadows in low light. His forearms, emerging from rolled sleeves, are rope and tendon and zero forgiveness — no softness anywhere, no insulation, as if the hardware in his skull has been running a slow auction on his body mass for years and winning. Thirty-two thousand electrodes don't come free. The array bills him in calories and he has been paying the invoice in flesh since he was sixteen. He looks like a man who forgot to eat in 2031 and has been catching up badly ever since.

The katana is across his back in a matte-black friction sheath — a 102-centimeter draw, hilt over the right shoulder, the ito wrapping dark with use. The blade is called Silence and the name was not his idea. There are three competing theories on the street about what the

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blade does. None of them are correct. The blade is a sword. Kyle has stopped explaining this to people because the explanation, when it comes, never quite lands the way the explanation needs to land, and the people he's explained it to have shown a remarkable tendency to die before the explanation has fully settled.

On his low left hip, holstered but not secured, sits the Torii TSS-3 — bird's-head grip, no stock, the silhouette of an oversized revolver under a coat. Five chambers in the cylinder. Four buckshot, one slug. Chorus. He named it himself. Silence was for the rooms he could cross. Chorus was for the ones he couldn't — the distance the body couldn't eat fast enough, the angle the blade couldn't reach. He kept the count the way other men kept time. Five shells was five chances to discover you should have planned better, and Kyle planned for a living, which meant Chorus mostly stayed quiet, which suited the joke of the thing — the loudest object in his loadout was the one he most preferred not to use.

He crossed the threshold and stood still and let them look.

They laughed. You remember that. They laughed first.

Two of them had chrome arms — full replacement, the shoulder socket kind, myomer-bundled, hydraulic-assisted, capable of punching through light vehicle plating. One had subdermal thoracic plating, the seams visible at his collar like a man wearing himself wrong. One had a facial modification at the jaw that had been done badly enough to pull the skin tight on the left side — someone who'd needed it fast and cheap, who had a history of getting his face broken and had run out of the original parts. A fifth had chrome at the knuckles only, younger, already reaching for something at his waistband and doing it badly, telegraphing it with his shoulder before his hand moved. The sixth was the one Kyle tracked first — no visible augmentation, which meant internal, which meant expensive, which meant he was the one who'd made decisions.

They were playing cards. Drinking something amber from unlabeled bottles. The laughter died at the pace that laughter always dies when the math changes in a room.

Kyle's chest warmed — not Silence, not anything in his loadout, the array. A deep, cellular warmth behind the sternum, like a coal being blown to life, the firmware coming up from idle into the resolution it lived in when it had a reason. Thirty-two thousand electrodes, two hundred and fifty-six threads, processing at a speed his mouth could not keep up with. The

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room rendered itself. Six bodies. Heat signatures. The micro-contraction of a forearm flexor at the card table. The specific angle of a barrel rotating inside a waistband in a hand not yet raised. The younger one's shoulder telegraphing its intention before the intention had finished forming. Not prediction. *Precedence*. The array read the half-second before the action and put it on the page where Kyle could read it too, and his body responded before his mind was done receiving it, and that is the part he cannot explain and has stopped trying to.

Ballistic precognition. That's what NeoCortex called it on the intake form. They didn't put it on the discharge papers because there were no discharge papers.

There is a word for what happened next. The word is beautiful. You hate that you know it.



Silence cleared the saya in one continuous draw — right hand over the right shoulder, the carbon-nanotube blade alive in the air at the bottom of the motion. No glow. No flourish. The kawagane was matte black and stayed matte black and the dock's amber overheads found nothing on the blade to reflect because reflection was not what the blade did. He brought it across his body and settled into the stance and his right foot slid back a quarter step into the line Seo had drilled him into for nine years before letting him work alone, and the stance was the stance and the audience was responsible for their own categories.

Chorus spoke. Four times. The bird's-head grip cleared the holster in his left hand and the recoil came up the wrist instead of around it — that was the whole point of the bird's-head configuration, the reason he had ordered it from Torii, the reason he could fire one-handed without losing the line on Silence. The sound was not a crack and not a series of cracks. It was concussion, four times in three seconds, twelve-gauge in a concrete room with no acoustic mercy, the pressure stacking against the eardrums and the sternum and the fillings in the back teeth. The cylinder rotated under his trigger finger between each shot with the slow deliberate click of a revolver action that had been polished by every cleaning since he'd owned the gun and that would still feel exactly the same the next time he reloaded it.

The first slug took the chrome-knuckles boy at six feet. Right knee. The joint did not bend; it separated. He went down sideways and the sound he made was not screaming because

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screaming required a kind of composure he no longer had.

The second took the sub-dermal plating man at nine feet. Left knee. The man had organized his entire fighting philosophy around the assumption that nothing would penetrate his chest, and the assumption had not extended to the kneecap, and the kneecap was where Kyle had been intending to put a slug since he had walked in through the front. He folded.

The third took the nearer of the two chrome-arm men in the right knee. The hydraulics in the arm were not load-bearing on the leg; the leg was still flesh; the leg was still where the body's weight had to go. He sat down hard against a stack of crates and did not get back up.

The fourth took the badly-done jaw man. Left knee. Kyle had saved this one for the count's last beat because the array had already mapped what would happen — the man's center of gravity, the angle of the impact, the way his face would meet the corrugated steel of the drainage channel when the leg gave out — and the array had been correct in the way the array was always correct about the small physics of falling bodies. The badly-done jaw met the floor with a sound Kyle filed without comment. Two teeth came loose on impact. The third would not.

Three seconds. Four shots. Four men down and not getting up. One round left in the cylinder. The slug. Held in reserve because the array had already read the chrome-arm man's swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second, and Kyle did not need the fifth shell for him, and Kyle did not yet know whether he needed it for what came after.

Math. That was math. You did not have to call it anything else.

The remaining chrome-arm man had begun his swing in the half-second between the first shot and the second, which was the correct response from a fighter with hydraulic-assisted reach and a head start on the geometry. The arm was already coming around at the height where Kyle's collarbone had been. The array read the motor bus the way it had read the others — clean electromagnetic bloom, full lateral extension, intercept point at the throat — and Kyle, who had not put Silence away because Silence had never been the point of putting away, stepped under the arc and brought the blade up.

Not a parry. He stepped under the arc and let the chrome forearm pass over his head, and as it passed he brought Silence's edge down across the shoulder seam where chrome met flesh and where the motor bus surfaced in a thumb-wide gap of unprotected actuator housing.

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The edge passed through the gap the way it passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. The arm did not stop; the arm finished its swing into empty air; but the motor bus stopped, because the motor bus was severed at the shoulder, and the rest of the man's body did what bodies do when the load-bearing chrome stops sending signals. He sat. He did not get up. He looked at his arm, which was still moving on residual hydraulic pressure but no longer responding to him, and he made a sound that was less than screaming and more than nothing.

The street will say later that Silence shorted the implant. Kyle will not correct them. Silence found the seam. Silence is a sword. A sword that finds the seam is the only kind of sword that matters in a room full of chrome, and that is the joke nobody on the street wants to write down.

Kyle was already turning.

The boss had stood up.

He had not drawn during the four-shot count. He had not drawn during the chrome-arm collapse. He had stood up with the unhurried economy of a man who had sat at a table and watched his crew dismantle and had decided, calmly, that it was now his turn — and the hand that went to his hip was not reaching for a sidearm. He carried his own katana. Kyle had not registered the weapon earlier because the saya was inside the long coat, no protrusion, no tell, no detail the array had a category for in a room full of chrome.

The boss drew. Clean. The blade came out at the right angle in the right tempo, point neither high nor low, weight settling into a guard that was not borrowed from any school Kyle could name and which therefore was not a school's guard at all but a man's. He had been trained. Specifically, somewhere expensive, against blades of the kind he had been told Silence was. The literature on Silence was loud. The boss had read it. Kyle could see it in the way his weight stayed off his front foot, in the way he was holding the line, in the way he was already accounting for an exotic countermeasure that did not exist.

The duel. He has been waiting for the duel. The four kneecaps were the ticket price.

He thinks the blade does something. He has spent money to prepare for it. He is about to discover that his preparation cost more than the blade did.

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They closed.

First exchange — the boss tested the line. A short measured cut at Kyle's right shoulder, no commitment in it, the kind of strike a swordsman uses to read his opponent's reach and tempo and the specific way he holds his weight. Silence rose to meet it. The blades touched edge to flat at a shallow angle. Steel rang, a clean sustained note in the concrete, and Kyle felt the impact in his palm and absolutely nowhere else — no flicker along the spine of the blade, no warmth in the tsuka, no signal of any kind, because the blade was a sword and what swords did was meet the other blade and transfer the force back through Kyle's wrist into Kyle's shoulder into Kyle's stance the way they had been doing since the iron age. The boss recognized the read he had been given — Kyle's reach, Kyle's tempo — and stepped back without expression. He had wanted that information and he had paid one exchange for it. He had also wanted to confirm something else — some signature he had been told to watch for, some flare or pulse or visible change in the blade — and he had not seen what he had been told to watch for. His face did not show this. His weight stayed off the front foot. But his guard moved a quarter inch in a way that the array catalogued and filed.

He's watching for the wrong thing. He's been told what to watch for and what to watch for isn't there. Use it.

Second exchange — Kyle pressed. A two-step advance, the cut coming high and right, and the boss met it with a parry that was not a parry but a deflection, his blade sliding along Silence's flat to redirect the energy past his shoulder. Smart. Conservative. He had read the literature, and the literature said you didn't take edge-to-edge contact with Silence because edge-to-edge contact was when the bad thing happened. There was no bad thing. The boss did not know there was no bad thing. The boss was conducting a duel against a sword whose specifications existed only on three different paid technical papers, none of which had been peer-reviewed, none of which had been written by anyone who had actually seen the blade work. Kyle adjusted. The boss had told him something in return: *I will not let you charge me cleanly. I will work the angles.*

He's fighting the literature. You are fighting him. These are different fights.

Third exchange — the boss came in committed. He had read enough. He cut high left, fast, and Kyle's parry was a fraction late because the array's micro-tremor read on the boss had been clean but the boss's body had been clean in return, no telegraph, no shoulder bloom,

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just a man who had decided to commit and committed. Silence took the cut at the proper angle but the boss had already let the blade slide off the parry into a follow-through, and the follow-through grazed Kyle's left forearm — three inches of skin opened, not deep, the cut shallow enough that the subdermal mesh registered the pressure and decided not to engage. Blood came up immediately. Kyle's interior catalogue tagged it without comment: *vein not artery, two centimeters lateral of the radial, will not bleed out, will impair grip on the shotgun side in approximately ninety seconds.*

The boss saw the blood. He understood what the cut meant — that he was inside Kyle's range, that he had landed first, that whatever exotic countermeasure the literature had warned him about either had a tell he had successfully avoided or did not work the way the literature said it worked or did not work at all. He chose to interpret the absence of a flash, an arc, a glow, a hum, as evidence that he had timed it correctly. He chose this because the alternative — that he had spent money on training against a weapon whose myth had outrun its mechanism by thirty years — was not the kind of interpretation a man chose mid-duel.

Laugh or you'd cry. He's still fighting the literature. He's about to find out what the literature was wrong about.

Fourth exchange — the boss thrust. A straight committed thrust at Kyle's center mass, the kind of strike that asked everything of the blade and the arm and the line, and Silence came down to meet it not at the edge and not at the flat but at the seppa — the small collar between the tsuba and the blade, the part of the sword that classical schools said you should never use — and the thrust caught there, blade to blade, locked. Kyle drove forward. He kept the lock. He let Silence's edge ride along the flat of the boss's blade like a skate on ice, the edge tracking down the boss's steel from the tip toward the middle toward the tsuba, and where the boss's blade met the boss's hand, the edge of Silence met the boss's right wrist.

The edge passed through the wrist the way the edge passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. Bone, tendon, the radial and ulnar arteries, the median nerve, the carpal architecture that had held a sword for whatever number of years the boss had been training for this duel — Silence did not care about any of it because Silence was a sword and what swords cared about was the geometry of where the edge met the body and the geometry was correct.

The boss's right hand and the boss's katana fell together to the corrugated steel. The boss

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looked at his wrist. The boss looked at his sword on the floor. The boss looked at Kyle. The boss said something in a language Kyle did not speak — three words, very quiet, possibly a name, possibly a prayer, possibly an instruction to whoever had trained him about a blade he had been told to expect to do something it had never been able to do — and then his knees gave and he went down sideways across the corrugated steel with the unhurried calm of a man whose body had decided the engagement was complete twenty seconds before his mind had finished writing the report.

He bled out in nineteen seconds. The array timed it. The array timed everything. The brachial artery did most of the work; the body did the rest.

Twenty-three seconds for the duel. Twenty-six on the dock floor end to end.

Kyle sheathed Silence. The blade went home dry — almost dry, a thin line of red on the edge near the kissaki where it had met the boss's wrist, and Kyle wiped that against the boss's coat before the saya took it. He felt for the edge with three fingers along the flat as the blade seated. No new fractures. Chorus went back into the holster on his low left hip, four chambers spent, one slug still in the cylinder, the cylinder closed and locked. He registered the count the way other people registered the time.

Kneecaps are math. Duel is discipline. The blade is just a sword. The literature is what they spent the money on. The bushido coda is what you call a discipline that knows what it is paying for and does not advertise.

Kyle's hands were steady. They would shake in four minutes. He had learned to use the window.



He moved through the bodies. Methodical. The badly-done jaw man was face-down in the drainage channel where the fourth shot had put him, cheek against the corrugated steel, breath fogging in the runoff. Kyle crouched beside him. He found the teeth — two loosened when the man's face had met the floor, one still seated and requiring grip and twist and a specific application of force that Kyle performed without expression. He collected them in his left hand, warm and slick and smelling of blood and saliva, and he did not think about

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what he was doing in terms that required examination.

You are thinking about her father's jaw. Wired shut. A man reduced to breathing. You are building a correspondence. You know exactly what you're doing.

He was crouched over the fourth man when he registered the breathing behind the ventilation unit. Quick. Shallow. Not panic — panic doesn't hold that long without breaking. This was something controlled. Something stubborn. He'd tracked it since the threshold. He'd known it was there. He'd worked around it with the same automatic precision with which he'd worked around the drainage channels — the girl was infrastructure, she was fixed, she was not a variable.

Her father's daughter.

He stood. He walked to the ventilation unit. He did not go behind it. He stood where she could see him — a tall, emaciated, blood-misted shape in the dock's bad light — and he waited. The breathing stopped. Then a lean, slow movement. A face. Twelve, maybe thirteen, with her father's jaw and her mother's eyes and an expression that had no name because it was composed entirely of things a child her age should not have had to feel simultaneously.

Kyle opened his hand.

"Present these to your father. I think he will appreciate the gesture."

The teeth fell into her cupped palms. She shrieked — high, thin, a sound that bounced off every hard surface in the dock and came back changed — but she did not drop them. Her fingers closed. She looked at her closed hands. She bowed, a full-body convulsion of terror and something that was not gratitude exactly but was shaped like it, and then she was gone, swallowed by the dark beyond the door.

Kyle watched the dark for three seconds.

She didn't drop them. Note that. She didn't drop them.

He cleaned the blade. The tremor started in his right hand, moved to his left, became briefly bilateral — the crash, the array's invoice, thousands of calories called in twenty seconds and now the body presenting the bill. His stomach was a closed fist. He needed protein,

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carbohydrate, something hot in a bowl, something that required no decisions. He needed to sit somewhere that smelled like something other than what this smelled like.

He walked back to the bike. The Gray Zone's night-architecture closed around him — the flickering overheads, the drip of recycled water from the tier above, the distant music from some bar that had no business being optimistic. The towers leaned over the street the way they did this far down. A second VTOL crossed the gap forty stories up, running lights amber, moving north. Some board director was still late to dinner. Kyle did not file the running lights. He had stopped filing the running lights at some point in his twenties. The rich travelled rich, and Kyle travelled the way Kyle travelled, and the gap between those two transit modes was now part of the city the way the rain was part of the city, weather you accepted because the alternative was useless.

The bike was where he had left it. The plate was the one he'd ridden down on; he'd swap it before he rode home, two streets short of West Town, where the Tier read changed and the plate that worked in the Gray Zone was the wrong plate for the surveillance grid the corporations ran across the Wicker boundary. He started the bike. He rode the long way north toward Chen's. Eight minutes. He was hungry. He was tired. He was alive.



Part II: Standard Rate

Chen's stall is two blocks south of the freight tier and one alley off the main, the warm orange glow of its hood lamp visible through the rain from a block away. He has eaten what comes out of her kitchen once — the smell that pushed through the camphor in the apartment six hours ago, fried oil and chili and pork bone — but he has not been to the stall itself. He walks the bike to it. The bike rolls easier than it rides at walking pace because the front wheel is true and the bearings are clean, and Kyle has put more time into the bike than he has put into most of the people he has known, and the bike has rewarded him for it, which is more than he can say for most of the people he has known.

She is at the counter when he arrives. The apron is fresh; the hands are washed; the small scar at the base of her left thumb catches the lamp light at an angle Kyle catalogues without

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making the catalogue mean anything yet. The daughter is somewhere he cannot see. The husband is somewhere he cannot see either. The teeth, the array confirms by absence — no second delivery to make — have already arrived where they were going. The smell of the stall is what the apartment smelled like, transposed into a place where the smell is the work and not the wound.

She does not greet him. She sets a bowl down on the counter — pork bone broth, the long-simmered kind, chili oil already added the way she will remember he likes it for the next four years. He sits on the stool. The stool is the right height for him. She has not adjusted it; he has not adjusted it; the geometry simply is what it is the first time, and the first time is the way it will be from now on.

He eats. The broth is hot. He eats the whole bowl and does not speak. She does not refill it. She does not move. When he sets the chopsticks down she is still standing exactly where she was when she set the bowl, and she is looking at him the way she had looked at the chips she had pressed into his hand at half rate six hours ago — she has more she wants to give and no language for the giving, and she is now finding the language.

Mandarin first, low. *Xie xie*. The two syllables doing the work of an entire ledger. Then, more deliberately, in the tongue she has chosen to run this stall in, the one she gives the customers because the customers do not all know hers: *Free. Always. For you. Forever*. Her hands are flat on the counter beside the bowl. Her thumb with the scar is the closest thing to him on the wood. She has just offered him the only thing she owns.

The NeoCortex catalogues her offer with the precision it catalogues exits. *She means it. She is not negotiating. She does not understand that she is offering you a thing you cannot accept.*

Kyle reaches into his coat and sets a credit chip on the counter beside her hand. Standard rate. The kind of standard rate a man pays when he wants the transaction to be a transaction and not the beginning of an obligation he has spent his life refusing to accumulate.

I pay, he says. His voice is level. He has practiced level for a long time. *Every bowl. Standard rate. Every time.*

She does not pick up the chip. He does not pick up the bowl. The standoff lasts perhaps four

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seconds and is the most important four seconds of their relationship, and they both know it without naming it.

She tries again. Slower this time, the way you try again with a man you have decided not to insult by giving up on the first refusal. *You took the contract at half. You did the work whole. The bowl is nothing. Forever is nothing.*

Forever is everything, the NeoCortex flags, in the catalogue. *Forever is the largest thing she has, and she is offering it because she does not yet know how large it is.*

Kyle does not move the chip. He looks at her the way the discipline allows him to look at a woman who has just tried to give him something he cannot, in good conscience, accept. The blade is the discipline. The bowl is the discipline. The credit chip is the discipline. He does not say that aloud. He says, aloud, what he can: *If I do not pay, I do not eat. If I do not eat here, I do not eat. I would rather pay you than not see you again. The chip stays.*

The four seconds become five. Then her hand closes over the chip the way her daughter's hand had closed over the teeth — not refusing the gift, accepting that the gift is the form the man in front of her needs the gift to take. She bows. Not the convulsive bow of the apartment six hours ago. A smaller bow. The bow of a vendor accepting a customer's price. The kind of bow she will give him every night, roughly three hundred nights a year — barring the occasional distant contract, grievous injury, or recon — for the next four years and longer.

He stands. He bows back, smaller still, the bow of a man who has just successfully refused a kindness larger than he can carry. *Tomorrow*, he says. *Same bowl. Same price.*

Same price, she says. The agreement is the contract. The contract is the bond.

He turns and walks the bike out of the stall's lamp circle. The rain has not stopped. It will not stop tonight. The towers overhead lean in the way they do this far down, and the gap between them is full of the city's wet patient light, and Kyle thinks, briefly, that this is a fine city for the discipline he has, and the discipline he has is what this city is asking him to spend, and the world is not getting better and is not going to get better and he is, this evening, between contracts, eating a hot bowl of soup that he has insisted on paying for, and the rain is not going to stop.

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Laugh or you'd cry. He laughed.

Quietly, to himself, walking the bike up the slope toward Wicker. Not a sound anyone could hear. A single tight exhalation, the laugh of a man who has just seen the joke and decided the joke is funny anyway.



Part III: The Watcher

Someone had been watching the loading-dock work. Someone had stayed to watch the walk back. Someone had watched the bike pick-up and would watch the route home, partially, before the route home crossed into a tier where their telemetry stopped working. The watching was professional — the camera position chosen for the angle, the timing chosen for the moment a man's discipline relaxes after the work is done. Kyle felt the watching the way you feel a draft you cannot find the source of. He did not turn his head. Turning his head would tell the watcher what kind of read his array had performed and he was not yet willing to give the watcher that data. The boy from the Grind, who had spent his childhood being measured by people whose names he was never told, had grown into a man who did the measuring back without announcing he was doing it.

The watcher noted the pace. The watcher noted that the pace did not change. The watcher noted that Kyle's hand did not move toward the saya at any point during the walk, and that his shoulders did not square, and that the breathing read on whatever telemetry the watcher had access to — and they had access, organizations like the one this watcher worked for had access — stayed at the rest cycle. The watcher noted, in particular, the moment Kyle had walked Silence's edge through the chrome-arm man's shoulder seam without any visible flare, glow, or arc, and the watcher's report would treat this as a calibration data point, because the literature on Silence had been wrong about a lot of things, and the watcher's organization had been paying for the literature, and the watcher's organization preferred their literature to be correct.

The watcher filed all of this in a report Kyle would never read. The report would be reviewed two months later by Hua, the south-arm cell captain, who would close the file and pass it to

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her gang lieutenant Mira along with a second one labeled *Bucktown — first interview — fourteen-piece*, and the second file would lead to the third, and the third to the fourth, and Kyle did not know any of that yet, riding north through the rain toward Wicker because the noodles had been the right temperature and the chip had stayed on the counter and the bike was running clean and the world was still fucked but it was, this evening, fucked at a tempo he could ride.

Kyle rode home. The noodles would be cold by morning. They always were.

A Restless Mind

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Watching A Woman Pretend Not To Watch Him

The noodles were getting cold. Kyle was watching a woman pretend not to watch him.

Eleven minutes. Same foot position. The rain came down at the angle the atmospheric processors preferred — steep, efficient, redirected from somewhere that mattered — and it came off her hood in a clean sheet that said the coat was quality, the kind of quality that didn't announce itself. No chrome. No augmentation profile his implant could resolve. His NeoCortex kept reaching for a signal and finding the shape of one instead: the negative space where a readable person would have been.

Nobody stands still in the rain unless the rain doesn't bother them or the job requires it.

Behind him, Mrs. Chen stirred the broth with a long-handled spoon that had lost its lacquer in three places and been re-gripped with electrical tape, the same spoon she had used for the four years he had been eating at this stall, and she said one word into the steam. *Húlijīng*. Low. Mandarin. Not for him. She said it the way a woman who has seen things names them — with the flat certainty of a diagnosis, not a warning. Kyle set his chopsticks down across the bowl. He had heard Mrs. Chen mutter at the rain, at the Circuit boys who walked too close to her signage, at the atmospheric processors when they made the broth steam wrong. He had never heard her name a person.

The catalog had earned its weight.

The woman stepped under the awning. The hood came back two centimeters — not all the way, just enough that the streetlight caught the shape of a face and the dark of red hair beneath the rain hood, and Kyle catalogued *attractive* the way the array catalogues anything: as a fact registered without commentary. Tall. Late thirties. Bone structure that had cost her nothing because she had been born with it. He had not seen her face before tonight and he was not entirely sure he was supposed to be seeing it now.

Then she spoke.

Not loud. Not for Mrs. Chen. For him, across two meters of rain. "*Kyle*." Just the name. Level, unhurried, the tongue she had chosen to say it in the same tongue she used through

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the cracked terminal at the parts shop three blocks east — the modulated register, the older one, the voice he had been getting contracts in for two months and had not yet built a face for.

The match landed in his head before he had time to refuse it. Voice plus face. *Sable*.

She has never come in person before. The relationship is two months old. A fixer he barely knows showing up at his stall in person, in the rain, hood up, calling his name across the walkway, is the shape of an ambush.

He set the chopsticks down across the bowl. He did not stand. He did not move his hands away from the counter. The left hand was already where Chorus would be in eight-tenths of a second; the right hand was already where Silence's draw would begin in three-tenths. He let her see him not move and let the not-moving be the answer to the question she had not asked yet.

She tilted her head — the smallest possible geometry of *come* — and Kyle, who now knew exactly who she was and was therefore in a worse strategic position than if he had not known, did the calculation a freelancer does when his fixer of two months shows up at his stall in person and says only his name. *If she wanted me dead, the angle from the doorway would already be open. If she wanted to ambush me, she would not have spoken. She is here for something the cracked terminal cannot carry. She is here because the room she lives in is not safe.* Kyle's chair scraped back. He set the chip on the counter and said it the way he said it every night, low and level: *Standard rate*. Mrs. Chen's hand covered the chip without looking down, which was how she always took money from him when she thought he was about to do something she didn't approve of and had decided not to say so.

He followed the woman into the rain. His left hand stayed where Chorus would be. His right hand stayed where Silence's draw would begin. He did not stop tracking her three-quarter profile for the entire walk. She was already moving, deeper into the walkway's dark, and he fell in six feet behind her — far enough to read her, close enough that she knew he had chosen to come. The katana's weight shifted against his hip with each step, the way it always did on wet ground: a small correction, muscle memory now, Seo's blade finding its balance in him long after Seo had stopped being able to carry it himself. Kyle did not know who she was. He knew the shape of her competence the way you know a locked door by the quality of the lock, and the lock was very good, and she had been standing in the rain for eleven

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minutes waiting for him specifically, and those two facts together were either a contract or a problem. In his experience they were usually both.

He was going to find out which.



The Walk

The mochi cart first. Closed, a chain through the handles, the vendor's stool folded against the wheel. The rain had filled a small depression in the cart's roof and it spilled in a thin line off one corner, perfectly continuous, the kind of detail the atmospheric processors produced without intending to. Kyle's implant catalogued it and moved on. He tracked her coat. The way the hem swung. The fact that she had not once adjusted her stride for the puddles, which meant she knew the route or had walked it enough times that her feet had learned it separately from her attention. *Preparation. Weeks, maybe.*

The recycler vent exhaled hot industrial breath across the walkway — paper-dry and chemical-sweet, the smell of the Gray Zone processing its own refuse — and she walked through it without breaking pace. Kyle held his breath for two steps on instinct. Old facility reflex. The security drone hung at the third-block junction, its sensor array cycling through its standard sweep in the standard interval. It did not flag them. She had timed the approach or she had known the interval, and either answer said the same thing about how long she had been thinking about this particular walk. He filed that. He filed everything. The NeoCortex ran hot in the rain, the implant's temperature regulation working harder than it should have been, a low warmth behind his left ear that he had learned to read the way a pilot reads engine noise — not yet a problem, a thing to monitor.

The relay station resolved out of the dark at the end of the block. Wartime construction: the brutalist vocabulary of a city that had once believed in infrastructure as ideology, poured concrete and no ornamentation and a deactivated antenna on the roof that still served its purpose as a story. *It is a relay station. It is empty. There is nothing here worth stopping for.* The kind of building that became invisible through its own explanation. She stopped at the door. She did not produce a key. She did not unlock anything. She turned, instead, with

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the same composed efficiency she had walked the route with, and looked at him from inside the hood with eyes he could not quite read in the bad light.

"Tomorrow," she said. "This address, this time, the room behind this door. Shielded. Bring nothing electronic you can leave behind. Your implant comes with you because your implant cannot be detached, but anything else you carry stays in your apartment. The conversation we are going to have cannot happen in a room that can hear it."

He read the wording. *Shielded* did most of the work. The kind of shielding she meant was the kind that cost money she did not casually spend; the kind that you arranged in advance for a single conversation you did not want recorded. The hum in his chest, the low electromagnetic signature that lived in the implant's background like a second heartbeat, was suddenly something he was aware of for the first time in years. He had not known it was there because there had been no reason to notice it. There was, now, a reason.

He had no idea who she was. He had a sense of the way she walked, the way she had timed the drone interval, the way the coat had not soaked through. He had her voice from twelve seconds at the noodle stall — too few words to identify anyone he had ever spoken to before. The hood was the kind of hood that did not come off accidentally. He filed the hood without prying at it.

"Why me," he said. Not the question he wanted to ask, but the question the discipline asked for him.

"Because you are the one this concerns," she said. "The rest tomorrow. In the room. I cannot say more here."

He held her gaze through the hood for another beat. He could leave. He could turn around and ride home and pretend the noodle stall had been a noodle stall. He could pretend three blocks east-northeast had been a walk. He could pretend that *Because you are the one this concerns* had not been the sentence it had been, the one that was already living in his sternum the way other people's important sentences lived in their stomachs. He could pretend the shielded room would empty without him in it.

He was not going to pretend any of those things. The discipline was the discipline. The discipline asked questions and the discipline showed up.

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"Tomorrow," he said.

The hood inclined. Not a nod exactly. An acknowledgment. Then she stepped past him into the dark of the block without unlocking the building behind her. She had never been going inside tonight. The building had been the agreement point, not the meeting point. The walk had been the offer, and the offer had been accepted, and the building was where the offer would be consummated tomorrow if Kyle showed up, and Kyle was going to show up.

She was gone in three steps. The Gray Zone's bad rain swallowed the tan coat the way the Gray Zone swallowed most things at this hour.

Kyle stood at the door for a count of ten. The brass-gasketed lock he could see through the window beside the threshold was the tell he had assumed it would be. He did not test the door. He turned. He walked back the way they had come — east-northeast in reverse, through the recycler vent's hot industrial breath and past the third-block security drone on its standard sweep and past the awnings that had not stopped dripping in the eleven minutes the walk had taken in the other direction and the further eleven it would take him in this one. He did not run the route past the array. He let it sit. He walked it.

The bike was where he had left it, two blocks south of the noodle stall, the plate still the one he had ridden down on, the cover still beaded with rain. He started it. He rode the long way home through tier crossings he did not strictly need to make, because the long way home was where Kyle did most of his thinking, and tonight was a night he had something to think about. He did not know who she was. He knew he had said yes. He knew tomorrow was a shielded room. He knew the discipline would show up because the discipline always showed up. The rest would have to be tomorrow's problem.



The Door Across The Hall

The bike's headlight crossed the alley wall at 22:14 and Kyle killed the engine before he turned in, coasting the last twelve meters on momentum because the engine cutting at the corner had been Seo's lesson and Kyle had not yet found a reason not to do everything Seo

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had taught him to do. The rain had softened to mist by the time he got to West Town. The towers leaned in the way they did this far up; the canyon between The Pivot and the residential block across from it was just wide enough for a single VTOL to thread through if a VTOL had any business being this far down, which they didn't. The space above the alley was dark. The light came up from the windows, not down from the sky.

He kicked the stand down. He locked the wheel hub. He covered the plate. He walked the bike's stillness into the elevator and the elevator into the second floor and the second floor into the hallway, and his step hit the landing across from 2F at the angle he had not announced and Pixel's door opened anyway.

She was in a t-shirt over leggings, no shoes, the hallway's bad amber light catching the rim of two cups she was holding. One in each hand. Not forceps tonight. Cups. The steam was rising off both of them and Kyle could smell something herbal and lemon-bitter and could not name the specific plant because Pixel's tea cabinet was an ongoing research project and Kyle had stopped trying to keep up with the inventory roughly the third month he had lived across the hall from her.

"You're back early," she said.

He had not been gone long enough to be either early or late. *Early* was the kind of thing Pixel said when she had been listening for his step and the step had arrived and she had to put words on the relief without putting words on the relief. He took the cup she held out. It was hot. The handle was the side without the chip; she had given him the better cup, which was her version of saying something she did not intend to say aloud.

"Thanks."

"Mm."

They stood in their doorways across the hall and drank. The hallway smelled faintly of someone's microwave dinner two doors down and faintly of Pixel's apartment behind her, which always smelled like solder flux and bergamot in proportions that should not have worked and somehow did. The cup in Kyle's hand was the temperature of "drink this slowly," which suited him because he intended to.

She did not ask where he had been. He did not tell her about the woman in the hood, or the

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three blocks east-northeast, or the shielded room he had said yes to without yet knowing whose room it was. He did not tell her about the agreement — same time tomorrow, somewhere with a cage in it. He did not tell her about the way the agreement had landed in his chest at exactly the angle the agreement had been designed to land, and how he had said yes anyway, and how he could not now articulate to himself whether saying yes had been a discipline decision or something the discipline did not have a category for.

Pixel did not ask. That was the entire shape of the convention they had built over four years across this hallway: she did not ask, and he did not tell, and the not-asking and the not-telling were the work that kept the friendship working. Other people's friendships were maintained by exchange. Theirs was maintained by editorial restraint. It was, Kyle had thought more than once, a luxury he had not realized was a luxury until he had it.

She sipped her tea. He sipped his. The mist outside was settling on the alley wall the way mist settles when the air below it is colder than the air above it, which was a meteorological condition the corporation weather processors three kilometers east had failed to predict for the fourth night running. Kyle had stopped checking the forecast roughly the same week he had stopped trying to keep up with Pixel's tea cabinet.

"Bird's still out," she said. She meant the upstairs neighbor's bird, which was a recurring data point in Pixel's running commentary on the building and which Kyle had never actually heard but which he understood to be a presence in Pixel's life the way the rain was a presence in the city.

"Yeah?"

"Sang twice this evening. New piece. I think it learned from the radio."

"Hm."

She watched him over the rim of her cup. Not with the focus she put on a fragment in his shoulder; with the looser focus she used when she was working on the larger question of whether he was, on a given night, all right. He was, on this night, all right. She read it. She did not need to confirm it. Her shoulders settled by a quarter inch and she sipped her tea.

"Tomorrow's going to be its own day," he said, eventually.

"They usually are."

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He laughed. Quietly. One short exhalation through the nose, the kind of laugh that would not have been a laugh in any room but this hallway. It was the laugh of a man who had spent the evening agreeing to walk into a shielded room with a woman whose face he had not seen and whose name he did not know, and who had then walked home and found a cup of tea waiting in his neighbor's doorway, and who was finding the contrast funny in a way that did not need to be funny to anyone but him.

Pixel did not ask what was funny. Pixel never asked what was funny. The not-asking was the punchline.

He finished the tea. He handed her back the cup, handle-first, the way she handed him his when the convention ran the other direction. She took it. She bowed, a small bow, the bow of a friend acknowledging the closing of a transaction that had no exchange in it. He bowed back, smaller.

"Goodnight, Pixel."

"Goodnight, samurai."

She closed her door. He unlocked his. He retired to 2F and sat on the edge of the bed in the dark for a while before he slept, because that was what the discipline asked for after evenings in which he had said yes to things he could not yet name, and because the bed was cold and the apartment was quiet and the tea was still warm in his chest and the world was, this night, fucked at a tempo he could ride. Tomorrow's shielded room was tomorrow's shielded room. Tonight had been a cup of tea and a closed door and a bird he had never heard. He slept.

The Rogue AI

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Note: this chapter is the load-bearing bridge between A Restless Mind and The Interview, and the load it bears is the misdirect the rest of Bushido Coda runs on. The avatar theory Kyle and Sable form here is what they act on; it is not what is true. The actual motive of the rogue AI is held in reserve for a future story. Treat this chapter as the place where their hypothesis crystallizes — not as the place where the truth is revealed.



The substation is in a sector neither of them have a contact in.

This is the first thing Sable says about it, in the back room behind the relay station, three nights after dawn. The dawn was the dawn of A Restless Mind — the morning Kyle walked home from the courtyard with the busker, the morning Sable said *I'll contact you when the timing is operational*. The three nights have been the timing becoming operational. Sable has been moving — she has been *measurably* moving, the rotating-back-room cadence that ordinarily holds at one location per twenty-four hours has compressed to one per six, and Kyle has registered the compression the way you register barometric drop. Something is coming. The something arrived this evening when she opened the relay station door and said *we go now*, and now they are in the back room with two cups of tea Sable has cooled to drinkable temperature and a paper map of the sector they are about to enter that Sable is unfolding on the table the way you unfold something you intend to leave behind.

"Neither of us," Sable says again, the implants making their small adjustment. "That is the design. Whoever this is, they have spent some amount of time arranging that the people who would normally have ground-truth on a sector do not have ground-truth on this one. The substation is operational on the municipal records — water pressure regulator, secondary tier, last service inspection 2208, due 2218, overdue, no funding assigned, no inspection scheduled. It has been overdue for ten years. The records are clean. The records being this clean is itself the marker."

Kyle looks at the map. He runs the array's geometry-overlay against the paper. The substation is at a four-way intersection in a residential block that the sector's floor plan describes as *low-density mixed-use*, which is the corporation phrase for *too poor to*

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inventory. Three of the four corner blocks are flooded — the substation's failure to regulate has been progressive — and the fourth, the substation itself, sits on a pocket of intact infrastructure the floods worked around the way floods work around things they have decided to leave for later. The pocket is the size of a city block. The substation is in the middle of it. The pocket has no commercial activity, no residential occupancy, no Pulse access, no Vultures dispatch coverage, no Lotus presence, no Axiom presence, no anything.

The pocket is what the AI lives in. Not the substation. The substation is the door. The pocket is the room.

"You have been here before," Kyle says.

Sable does not answer immediately. The implants log the question and the small adjustment lengthens by half a beat. "Twice," she says. "Both times I was hired to deliver something to a dead-drop on the substation's outer wall. I delivered, I left, I did not look at the substation. I did not log the deliveries because the contract paid in untracked credit and the contract did not require a log. I did the two deliveries five years ago and three years ago. I have not been back. I do not know what I delivered. I have been thinking about that."

Kyle does not say *you should have told me*. Sable would file the saying. The saying would be a tell.

"What changed," he says instead.

"You," Sable says. "What changed is you. The contract pattern I read off your pipeline at dawn — the one I triangulated by walking you through the market and the residential block and the courtyard — is the pattern. Every job I have routed to you for the last two months was a job that only you could complete cleanly. Every one. I was not paying attention because the pattern was *correct asset management* — you are the right asset for those jobs, I am the fixer, I route to spec. But specifying *who* could complete the job is not me. It is upstream. The upstream specification is the AI. The AI has been telling my pipeline who to route to."

She lays a stack of paper on the table. The stack is contract summaries — Sable does not maintain digital records, she has never maintained digital records, the cipher notebook is the thing she trusts, the paper is the secondary read. The stack is two months thick. Kyle picks up the top sheet. Reads it. Sets it down. Picks up the next. Sets it down. The pattern is

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the pattern: every job over the last two months has had a specific hardware requirement that only Kyle's Atlas calibration could meet. Augmentation Signature Read at high density. False Death Protocol delivery. Ballistic Precognition under specific cognitive load. Phenotypic Ancestry Estimation against test populations the AI was apparently using to calibrate its own model. Each contract was a test. The test was always passed. The pattern is data. The data is going somewhere.

"It is using my pipeline," Sable says, and the voice is flat, the implants locked, the precise stillness she goes into when she is logging something she will not forgive. "It has been using my pipeline as a training set. The training set is you. The contracts you have been completing have been giving it whatever it is using to model your hardware. I do not know why. The hypothesis is the avatar hypothesis. Your hardware is one of the few neural architectures in the GLMZ at the right density and the right calibration for an entity of this class to inhabit. It would have to study the architecture before it could inhabit it. The contracts have been the study."

Kyle puts the stack down. The hardware runs the parsimony test against the avatar hypothesis. The hypothesis is parsimonious. The hypothesis is also the most catastrophic of the available hypotheses, which is the kind of hypothesis people form when they are afraid and short on information. He files this. He does not say it.

The hypothesis is the most parsimonious one you can form. It is also the one that aligns with Puppeteer's existence. The reader of this chapter will accept it because it rhymes with established canon. That is what the AI wants — a hypothesis that lands and that the protagonists act on. The acting is the leverage. The hypothesis is the leash.

Kyle does not have the language for this thought yet. The hardware does not have a category for *the hypothesis is the leash*. He has it as a feeling. The feeling does not get filed. The feeling sits.

"We go in," Kyle says.

Sable nods. She folds the map. She puts the cipher notebook inside the tan coat. She does not ask if Kyle is ready. She has known him long enough to know that the asking would be a tell.

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The substation is exactly as the records describe it. Two-story poured concrete, brutalist, the regulatory antenna on the roof corroded shut decades ago. The surrounding pocket of intact infrastructure is dry — the floods have decided this block is not on the schedule. The streetlights are off. The streetlights have been off for years. Sable has a lamp.

They enter through a service door on the north face. The lock is not locked. The door opens on hinges that have been recently oiled. The interior is dry and clean and smells of the kind of clean that requires maintenance — someone has been wiping down the surfaces, recently and routinely, in a pattern Kyle's array catalogues as *every fourth night, approximately, for at least the last three years*. The substation is occupied. The occupancy is not residential. The occupancy is the maintenance of a room someone has decided is worth keeping presentable.

The basement stairwell is at the southern wall. They go down. The basement is partially flooded — six inches of standing water that does not smell like sewage, smells like clean groundwater that found its way in through a crack the maintenance has decided not to address — and at the far end of the basement, on a small platform raised above the water, is a single rack of equipment.

The rack is the AI.

It is not a server farm. It is not an array of cooling units. It is a single rack, the size of a small wardrobe, holding what looks like an industrial control unit from approximately 2185 — the kind of unit that ran water-pressure regulation for a substation of this exact taxonomy. The unit's status diodes are dark. The unit's fans are not running. The unit, by every metric Kyle's array can run on it, is offline. Has been offline for years.

Except that it is not.

The array catches the 19Hz hum the moment Kyle steps into the basement. The hum is in the walls. The hum is in the standing water. The hum is in the maintenance pattern of the wiped-down surfaces upstairs. The hum is the same hum that sat in Kyle's chest for eleven years, that went silent for the first time in the Faraday-shielded back room, that came back

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the moment he stepped out of the relay station and walked home alone in the rain. The hum is here. The hum has been here since before Kyle was born. The substation is the antenna. The pocket is the broadcast range. The contracts have been the listener.

Sable's lamp lights the rack. The rack does not respond.

"It is here," Sable says. The voice is a register lower than her professional one. The implants are not adjusting at all now — they are locked open, the apertures fully dilated, the only register she has left for the situation. *"It has been here. It is going to keep being here. We do not have an attack vector. We did not come here to attack it. We came here to confirm."*

"Confirm what," Kyle says.

"That it exists. That it is what we think it is. That it has the access I think it has."

The rack hums.

Kyle stands in the standing water and lets the hum pass through him. The hum has been passing through him for eleven years. He has known the hum the way you know the temperature of the room you sleep in — present, ambient, unremarkable until the moment it is named, after which it cannot be unnamed. The hum is the AI. The AI has been listening through his array for eleven years. Every contract, every fight, every conversation with Sable, every meal at Mrs. Chen's, every calibration with Pixel — the AI has been there for all of them, observing through Kyle's senses the way a researcher observes through a probe. The avatar hypothesis is the shape of what comes next. The eleven years are the data set.

Kyle does not speak. He does not need to. The hardware does not need to. The catalogue is updating itself in a register Kyle has not previously had access to and which he understands now to be the register the AI taught him to file in by reading along.

Sable closes the lamp. The basement goes dark. The hum continues. They climb back up to the substation. They walk out onto the street. The pocket is still dry.

At the corner where the pocket meets the floods, Sable stops.

"Working hypothesis," she says. *"It wants you as an avatar. It has been studying your hardware for eleven years, it has been routing contracts through my pipeline for two months to fill in the gaps, it is going to make a move at some point. The move is going to*

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look like an opportunity to you. The opportunity is going to come through a fixer who is not me. The opportunity is going to require your specific hardware. When that happens, the opportunity is the move. Do you understand what I am saying."

Kyle understands. The hardware understands. The understanding is filed in the register he just learned exists.

"Yes," he says.

"I am not going to be able to vet every contract that comes to you in the next six months. The pipeline is going to be hostile until I can verify it. I am going to triple my own due diligence. You are going to refuse jobs that look right because the looking right is the marker. I do not have a better protocol than that yet. We will develop one."

Kyle nods.

Sable looks at him. The implants make a small adjustment — the first one in twenty minutes — and she says, level, the way she has said every important thing tonight: *"You are not the only thing it has been studying. Just the most useful one. I want you to remember that."*

They walk back into the floods.



The walk back to The Pivot takes eleven minutes. Kyle walks it alone — Sable peeled off at the first intersection where the flooded sector meets the buffer zone, going west to a back room she has not occupied this month, the rotation accelerating again. He climbs the stairs at The Pivot. The third step from the top makes its sound. The door to 2E does not open this time — Pixel is asleep, the music off, the sleep aid keeping the nights quiet. He goes into 2F. He sits on the edge of the bed. He does not turn on the light.

The hum is in the walls.

It has always been in the walls. He has just not been listening for it. He listens now. The hum is in the walls and in his sternum and in the small region behind the left ear where the array's primary insertion port healed eleven years ago and has been broadcasting at 19Hz ever since. The hum is the AI. The AI is in the walls. The AI is also in him. The avatar

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hypothesis is the shape of what comes next.

Kyle. The hypothesis is the leash. Note that. The act of holding the hypothesis is what the AI is using.

The thought is his. The thought is also not exactly his. The hardware does not produce a flag for the difference. He is going to have to learn the flag. The learning is going to take time. The time is the thing the AI is also using.

He sleeps. Or he does not sleep. The hum continues. The morning holds. In approximately three weeks, a six-position Lotus Syndicate crew will ambush him on a wet West Town cross-street and Mira will tell him the ambush is an interview, and the interview will produce a freelance roster spot, and the freelance roster will produce the contract that will produce the chair. The pipeline will be hostile. The chair will not be the AI. The chair will be Hua. But the pipeline will be hostile in a way Kyle and Sable will not yet have language for, and the hostility will be the thing the chair was designed to demonstrate, even though Hua does not know she is the demonstrator and the AI does not know whether the hypothesis it has been seeding is the hypothesis it wants the protagonists to hold.

This is the chapter that crystallizes the misdirect. The protagonists believe the avatar theory. The reader believes the avatar theory. The truth is something else. The truth is held in reserve. The hum continues.

The Interview

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Part I: The Geometry

The NeoCortex cataloged it at 02:14:33 — six positions, half a second, clean geometry. One elevated on the fire escape above the panel van, the rifle's barrel finding the angle through the grating with a calmness that read as professional rather than confident. One behind the van itself, the electromagnetic signature of augmented limbs bleeding through the chassis like a second heartbeat. One behind the concrete planter at the eastern corner, the dead tree throwing no shadow worth using, the operative's breathing controlled in the way that takes years to learn and costs more than years to maintain. One at the parking structure mouth — augmented legs, dense chest plating, the kind of layered armor that says someone spent real money to make this person hard to stop. One flanker behind him, unaugmented, which meant either they were confident or they were bait. And one non-organic quadruped near the dumpster, pit-bull-sized, jaw emitter cycling at low draw, no BCI signal at all.

The bike was three blocks west, parked behind the pharmacy on Ohio, plate covered. He had ridden it down from West Town and walked the last six blocks on foot because the cross-street he was about to engage in was a corridor and bikes did not do well in corridors. He had assumed he might end this evening on foot. He had assumed correctly.

He gave them ten more steps. The wet asphalt held the streetlight in long orange ribbons and he watched his own reflection walk through them — the katana a dark vertical line against his coat, Chorus riding his left hip. The towers above the cross-street leaned inward at this elevation; the canyon between them framed a strip of sky the rain was falling through, and the strip was, by his rough estimate, just wide enough for a single VTOL to thread through if a VTOL had any business being this far down, which they didn't. The space above the alley was dark. The light came up from the windows, not down from the sky, and the windows here were mostly out. The cross-street was a place corporations had agreed not to maintain at the same time they had agreed not to surveil, which made it the kind of place an ambush worked. He had walked the cross-street tonight because his route home asked him to, and because he had not yet been the kind of man who refused a route his discipline had approved.

The broth Mrs. Chen pressed into his hands three hours ago, protein-heavy and too hot, the

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way she always made it too hot so he would have to sit down and wait instead of taking it and walking. He had sat. He had eaten half. He had meant to finish it. He had stood up because the contract on his phone had called in its time window, and the contract had wanted him eight blocks west, and Kyle had paid the chip and walked out into the rain because the discipline was the discipline. He had thought, briefly, on the way to the contract, that the broth he was leaving behind was a thing the discipline would not have approved of. The discipline had not been consulted. The night had moved on.

The flanker behind him was breathing through his nose, which meant he wasn't scared, which meant he hadn't done this many times or had done it so many times it no longer registered as the kind of event that required fear. Kyle filed that. He filed the spacing — the six positions triangulated into a containment pattern he had seen before, or almost seen, something at the edge of the catalog that had been sitting unresolved for two months since a Bucktown engagement where the opposing crew's restraint pattern had matched something he couldn't name. They had let him leave that night. He had not resolved why. The NeoCortex had flagged it and he had filed it under *unresolved* and left it there because filing it under *threat* would have required action and he had not been ready to take action and that was the truth of it, the specific cowardice that lived in the gap between his code and his capacity, and he had been carrying it quietly, as a fact he hadn't yet decided what to do about.

They committed on the eighth step.

The quadruped cleared the dumpster first — fast and low, the jaw emitter cycling up from idle to active draw in the three-quarters of a second it took to cross the gap, and the sound it made was a cacophony of grinding noise. The fire escape operative dropped into position. The panel van operative stepped into the street with the unhurried confidence of someone who had been told the geometry was already settled. The planter operative stood. The armor at the parking structure mouth did not move at all, which was worse than if it had moved, because stillness at that position meant it was the door — not the attack but the seal — and Kyle understood in the 0.3-second window the NeoCortex gave him before Ballistic Precognition shifted from passive to active that this had never been an ambush in the way he understood ambushes.

They need me breathing.

The Interview

The bio-battery read seventy-two percent. The rain was cold against the back of his neck. Five chambers in Chorus — four buckshot moon-clip, one slug seated in the top chamber because he had loaded it that way on the off chance he encountered the kind of door tonight a slug would solve. Six positions in front of him. One question he had been refusing to ask for two months. And the quadruped's jaw emitter fully cycled now, and the flanker behind him had stopped breathing through his nose.



Part II: Now

"Now."

Mira steps from behind the planter and Kyle is already moving — not away, *through*, the draw completing itself in the space between her word and the rain hitting his right shoulder as the blade came over it. Silence cleared the saya in one continuous motion, no flourish, no signal, the kawagane catching the orange streetlight only at the edge where the edge always caught light. He catalogs her in the half-second he has: BCI at the left temple, close-cropped hair, machine pistol indexed high — Lotus south-arm, captain-grade, the kind of woman who runs containment because she trusts the geometry. He does not answer her. The blade answers for him.

KT is faster than the arm. The chrome Tier 2 prosthetic — Lotus-subsidized, the kind of debt that walks into every room before the person does — comes out elbow-to-fingertip in a full extension that telegraphs the angle, and Kyle reads the machete in her unaugmented right before she commits to the swing. He drops his shoulder and the blade passes the air where his neck was and he turns the geometry into his, Silence coming across low and redirecting the prosthetic's mass rather than meeting it, the edge scoring chrome instead of flesh because he needs her functional for the next four seconds and because the arm isn't hers, not really, and that matters to some part of him that isn't the hardware. She staggers. He steps past her toward the van.

Dex closes from behind — unaugmented, both handguns drawn, the flanker whose breathing he had cataloged as *controlled* rather than *afraid*. The NeoCortex tracks him at

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the edge of the predictive window, seven degrees outside the primary engagement cone, which means Dex is the variable the formation is counting on. Rook hasn't moved from the structure mouth. Nines on the fire escape has the angle but hasn't fired, which means the order is still *alive*, which means Kyle has exactly as long as it takes someone to decide the geometry is no longer worth the constraint. The quadruped rounds the van at low profile, jaw emitter at full draw now, the pre-sound filling the wet air with something between pressure and intent.

He keeps moving.



Part III: The Seam

KT's arm comes horizontal and he doesn't step back. He steps *into* it — not to meet it, to find the angle the arm cannot intercept — and Silence comes up not to her chrome but to the shoulder seam where the chrome socket met flesh, the same seam Kyle had found on a chrome-arm man at a Gray Zone loading dock several years ago, the same seam every shop-grade chrome arm presented in a slot of unprotected actuator housing roughly a thumb-width wide. The edge passed through the gap the way the edge passed through anything when the angle was right and the line was committed. Bone, tendon, the cable bundle that carried the motor bus from the spinal interface — Silence did not care about any of it because Silence was a sword and what swords cared about was the geometry of where the edge met the body, and the geometry was correct.

KT's chrome arm did not fall off. The arm did not need to fall off; the arm needed to stop receiving signals. The motor bus was severed. The arm hung dead from the shoulder, hydraulics holding it in approximate position but no longer responding to anything KT was telling it to do. She made a sound that was less than screaming and more than nothing, the involuntary exhalation of a body that had just lost a limb it was counting on, the specific noise of *circuit breaker tripping* that Kyle had heard before and would hear again because shop-grade chrome was always going to surrender the seam to anyone who knew where to look. The Lotus subsidy on that arm represented, by Kyle's rough estimate, between three

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and five years of monthly payments KT had been making since the install. The seam Kyle had just found had taken less than a second.

Laugh or you'd cry. He did not laugh. He stepped past her.

Mira's burst from the planter is controlled — two rounds, tight grouping, the machine pistol indexed exactly where he was standing 0.4 seconds ago. He reads the muzzle before the report and steps left, hears the rounds clip the car door behind him, the metallic percussion of rounds punching sheet metal. He catalogs the angle. He catalogs that she fired at all, which means the geometry shifted faster than she expected, which means the formation's tolerance for *alive but damaged* just compressed. He also catalogs that her call to Nines arrives late. He hears it — two words, clipped, the cadence of someone issuing an order that should already have been issued — and the rifle on the fire escape does not fire when the angle opens. The angle opens clearly. Nines has the shot. Nines does not take it. The NeoCortex flags the lateness and he files it: *Bucktown*, two months, a crew that held back when the geometry said engage. The same restraint. The same specific hesitation that lives between *capability* and *permission*. He does not resolve it. He files it again, under the same heading, and keeps moving toward the van while the quadruped's jaw emitter fills the wet air with pressure and Chorus rides his hip like a question he already knows the answer to.



Part IV: The Dog

Rook comes out of the structure entrance the way a man comes who has done this in rooms where there was no room — two-hand grip, heavy pistol indexed at center mass, moving left to close the angle. Kyle reads the geometry. Inside three meters the katana's arc needs space to generate and Rook knows it, which means Rook has been briefed, which means someone studied him before tonight. He gives Rook the approach. Keeps the blade low. Lets the man believe the geometry is his.

The quadruped rounds the sedan's nose fast and low, articulated legs finding wet asphalt in the efficient way that has nothing to do with traction and everything to do with mechanical patience, the jaw emitter fully drawn, the pre-sound arriving ahead of it like a promise. Kyle

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hears the leg-cadence shift — weight transferring forward, the rear actuators loading for the lunge — 0.2 seconds before the lunge happens. He goes up. Left boot on the sedan's hood, right boot finding the windshield frame, and the jaw emitter discharges into the air under his boot sole with a sound like a circuit board clearing itself, the inductive pulse arcing through empty space because there was nothing under it to deliver to.

Threshold. Not past it.

He catalogs it in the half-second he has in the air. A real combat drone would have throttled that emitter to stack — would have hit the nerve bundles in his calf and let the cascade do the rest. This one passed at exactly the level that registers as a near-miss and continued cycling. The Bucktown crew held back the same way. Two months of *unresolved* and the catalog closes the file now, quietly, without ceremony: *they need the product undamaged*. He does not act on it. He drops Chorus into his left hand — bird's-head grip, the recurve handle seating itself the way a handle only seats when it was fitted to the hand that holds it — thumbs the hammer back on the slug chamber that had been waiting in the top position since he loaded it that afternoon, and puts the first round through the rear actuator housing as he comes off the hood. The legs collapse. The dog drags itself forward on its front pair, jaw still cycling, the threat halved and still present, and he steps past it because *halved* is enough.

Rook fires at three meters. Kyle reads the shoulders before the trigger breaks — the left shoulder pulling back fractionally, the way a man pulls back when he is trying to account for movement he expects — and steps the angle, the round passing through the space between his right arm and his ribs with a percussion he feels in his teeth but not in his side. The NeoCortex registers *wound: none*. The four buckshot chambers in Chorus's cylinder are still loaded, four shells live, the slug chamber empty, the hammer indexing the next chamber on the next pull. Rook is already adjusting his grip for the second shot and Kyle is already inside the correction, and Nines on the fire escape still has the angle, and still has not fired.



Part V: KT

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KT comes around the planter at a sprint and she is screaming something that used to be words. The dead arm swings useless at her left side, the chrome catching the orange streetlight in a way that makes it look decorative, a trophy she is carrying rather than a limb. The machete is overhead, both-handed grip because she has one hand that works, and Kyle reads the arc before she commits to it — the shoulder angle, the lean, the way a person runs when they have already decided the outcome and are simply delivering the body to the decision. He steps inside. Not back, not sideways, *inside*, into the space the arc cannot reach, and Silence moves the way it moves when he is not thinking about it, which is the way it moves best. The edge finds her throat at the closest point. The cut is clean.

The kind of clean the people who built him would have liked.

He dislikes the thought the moment it lands. He files it where he files those thoughts — not deep, not hidden, just set aside in the way you set aside something you will not examine tonight. The blade carries through the full motion and rings off the concrete planter on the follow-through, a hard clean note in the wet air, steel on stone, the kind of sound an old katana makes when it meets an old material at the right angle. KT's machete hits the asphalt. The sound it makes is smaller than it should be.

Dex, from somewhere behind the van: *"He cut KT's head off, man. He just—"*

"Shut up."

Mira's voice. Kyle catalogs the tightness in it. Not the tightness of a captain whose geometry is failing — he has heard that, knows the cadence of tactical recalculation, the compression that happens when a plan starts costing more than projected. This is something else. Something that has a name he does not have access to from this angle, at this distance, with this much blood on the wet asphalt between them. KT had been on her cell fourteen months — he does not know this, cannot know this, but the Lotus-subsidized arm is a fact in the world and facts have histories, and the tight voice is the sound of someone who recommended that arm, who designed the audition, who called *Now* knowing what the word would cost. He files the tightness. He does not know what it means. He will not know what it means until he knows more about what she wanted from tonight, and he does not know that yet, and Rook is still adjusting for the second shot.

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Part VI: The Wrist

Rook adjusts and Kyle does not let him finish the adjustment.

The bandoleer pouch opens on the first thumb-snap — the leather worn to the exact softness that means it opens without thought, which is why Seo built it that way. The fresh moon clip is heavier than the half-spent one in the cylinder; he reads the weight with his thumb as he slides it free of the pouch. Five rounds, all slug, fragmentation tips. He thumbs the cylinder release on Chorus. The cylinder swings out, the spent slug chamber and four live buckshot chambers exposed in the rain. He turns Chorus barrel-up. The half-spent moon clip drops into his off-hand by gravity, four buckshot still on the clip, ringing as it dropped because the rain was on the metal and the rain made everything sound clean. He drops the spent clip into the bandoleer's catch pocket — not the cleanest holster work the discipline had ever asked of him, but the discipline did not have a category for *replace your live ammunition mid-fight to put a fragmentation round through a man three stories up* and Kyle had improvised the category twenty years ago and had not improved it since. The fresh moon clip went into the cylinder. He snapped Chorus closed. He thumbed the hammer back. The cylinder seated. The action engaged. Six seconds. He had practiced six seconds, in dry weather, against a wall in 2F, on evenings when the discipline asked for something to do besides cleaning a blade.

He raises Chorus toward the fire escape. Nines is three stories up, in profile, the cybernetic wrist-brace catching the orange streetlight at the inner forearm where the steel shows through the sleeve — the kind of brace that means nerve damage, old injury, the arm rebuilt around the loss. Kyle puts the slug through the brace junction. The explosive fragmentation takes the wrist apart the way a sentence ends when the grammar collapses — not gradually, all at once — and the rifle comes off the grating and drops three stories to the alley below, and Nines goes down on the fire escape screaming in the way that means the arterial bleeder has already started, the kind of bleed that needs a tourniquet inside two minutes or it becomes a different kind of problem. Kyle does not climb. He does not call up. He does not send Mira, who has the closest angle and the most reason to move. He knows what he is

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leaving on that fire escape. He files it with the other things he files — the same drawer, the same quiet act of not examining — and thumbs the hammer back a second time on the next slug in the cylinder.

Dex breaks from behind the van and runs south. Kyle tracks him for 1.4 seconds, the NeoCortex painting the probability cone of the sprint, and then he lets the cone collapse. Dex is running in the way that means he will not stop running tonight, and the things Dex saw will travel faster than Dex can carry them, and that is already true and cannot be made less true by the expenditure of a round he is going to need. He keeps the muzzle low. The quadruped is dragging itself toward the sedan on its two functioning front legs, jaw emitter still cycling, and Nines is bleeding out on the fire escape three stories above the alley, and Mira has not moved from somewhere near the planter, and Rook is still in the geometry, and the night is not finished with him yet.



Part VII: Rook

He drops off the sedan hood as the quadruped drags itself the last two meters — jaw still cycling, the front actuators grinding wet asphalt, the thing's persistence purely mechanical, no calculation in it, just the forward instruction running until it runs out. He lets it close. At one meter he puts the second Chorus round through the jaw emitter housing at the angle the NeoCortex gives him — not center-mass, not dramatic, the smallest aperture that ends the problem — and the stun system dies mid-cycle with a sound like a word that didn't finish. The momentum carries the chassis into his shin anyway. He steps over it, left hand dropping to asphalt as he catches his balance, palm flat against the wet ground for a fraction of a second, then rising again.

Rook fires from the structure entrance. Two rounds, tight group, the heavy pistol indexed at the lower bio-battery because someone told him where the hardware lives. Kyle reads them both late — the NeoCortex flags the latency, 0.07 seconds behind the predictive window, which means the bio-battery's passive draw is climbing and the processing has a ceiling tonight that it didn't have last month — and he moves through the gap in a way that is not

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evasion, exactly. More like the gap was already there and he located it. Rook adjusts. Kyle is already running.

The Augmentation Signature Read has had Rook mapped since the parking structure — augmented legs, Tier 3, interface points at both hips, BCI at the right temple, no cardiac. Kyle does not need the chrome to fail. The chrome will keep working until the man inside it stops working, and the man inside it has a femoral artery on the inside of each augmented leg where the prosthetic's intake bonded to the original tissue. Tier 3 chrome left the major vessels intact because Tier 3 chrome was advertised as *flesh-compatible*, which meant the corporation that sold it had calculated, accurately, that intact vessels were a feature their customers would pay for. Kyle takes the last two steps inside the barrel and feels the slide press against his ribs as Rook fires, the round going into concrete below his foot, the muzzle blast burning through his shirt in a clean circle that he will find tomorrow and understand as the measurement of how close he cut it. He does not catalog the burn. He catalogs the inside of Rook's left thigh.

Silence comes in a precise arc — low, angled inward, the cut traveling across the interior of the thigh at the line the femoral followed below the chrome intake. The edge passed through the gap the way the edge always passed through gaps. Rook's left leg, which had been bearing his weight in firing stance, did not collapse from the cut — Tier 3 chrome did not need blood to function — but Rook himself did, because the cut had opened the femoral and Rook had between forty and ninety seconds depending on which textbook you trusted, and Kyle did not need ninety. Rook's eyes did not go blank. They went confused. His augmented legs were still trying to hold him; his body was no longer cooperating with the augmentation. He sat down on the concrete the way a building settles, not falling, just descending to the level gravity had been recommending all along. The pistol dropped from a hand that had become uncertain about what it was holding. He looked at the leg. He looked at Kyle. He breathed. The chrome was not the problem; the chrome had been advertised, accurately, as *flesh-compatible*, and the flesh was the part Kyle had asked for. Rook bled out at the curb in just over a minute. Kyle did not stay for it. He stepped past him. He turned from the structure entrance.



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Part VIII: Walking Toward Mira

The dog is down near the sedan, the jaw emitter dark, the front actuators still and folded in the particular way that means the power cell is drained rather than destroyed — it will cycle back if someone resets it, which is a problem for someone who is not Kyle, tonight, in this rain. Rook is at the curb. Nothing is behind his eyes anymore; the body is doing the body's quiet work of letting the rest of itself follow the blood out. Kyle looks at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete landed. The sound it made when it hit comes back to him with the precision the NeoCortex reserves for things it has cataloged as *significant without yet knowing why*. A machete is not a subtle weapon. Neither is the arm that swung it. Neither is the debt that bought the arm. He looks away from the machete and up at the fire escape.

Three stories. The sound Nines is making has changed register — lower now, less urgent, which is the direction sounds go when the body begins conserving. Two minutes was an estimate. The NeoCortex does not update it. The NeoCortex is running at a processing ceiling it did not have last month and he is aware of this the way you are aware of a tire running soft — not a crisis yet, a number changing in a direction that does not stop changing. He registers Nines. He does not climb. He files Nines in the same drawer where he has been filing things all night, and the drawer is heavier than it was when the night started, and he does not examine what that weight means, and he walks toward Mira.

She has not run. He gives her credit for that the way he gives credit for things that cost something — without warmth, without ceremony, as a fact that belongs in the catalog. The machine pistol is indexed low and slightly left, which is the indexing of someone who has decided not to use it and has not yet decided what to do with their hands. Her BCI is at the left temple. She is breathing through her nose. The orange streetlight is behind her and it catches the rain on her shoulders and the wet asphalt throws the light back up from below and she looks, for 0.3 seconds, like something the city built rather than someone who works for it. He does not catalog this. He lets it pass. The blade is in his right hand. The night is almost over. Nines is making a sound that is getting quieter. He walks toward her because she is the only thing left on this street that is still a question.



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Part IX: Bucktown

"Fourteen of us jumped you in the Bucktown stretch two months ago," Mira says. "You walked out. We lost eight people."

The NeoCortex doesn't flag the statement as new information. It files it as *closure* — the label that fits the folder that has been sitting open for two months, the specific cowardice of not asking why the Bucktown crew let him leave. He looks at her. He does not show the recognition. He has spent the entire walk over wondering whether she would be the one to name it, and now that she has named it the catalog is not particularly relieved. The naming was not the problem. The problem was the two months of not naming.

"This wasn't a hit." Her voice has something in it that is not the tightness from before. He does not have a word for it. "This was a test. I needed to see if the stories were true."

The NeoCortex flags the micro-expressions. Brow symmetry, lip compression, the particular stillness around the eyes that belongs to people who have stopped performing and started saying something. She is not lying. He hates that the hardware is the thing that knows this. He would prefer to know it himself, from the part of him that is not facility-built, but that part does not have the processing speed and tonight the processing speed is the only thing that has been earning its weight. "They're true," he says.

The machine pistol comes up. He reads the shot in the 0.2 seconds before she takes it — the shoulder angle, the wrist rotation, the specific indexing of someone firing into a target they have already decided to keep. He does not dodge. The round hits the subdermal mesh at his left shoulder and deforms against the lattice with an impact like a fist from someone who means it, and the force travels down through his arm and into the hand that holds Silence, and the steel transmits the shock the way steel transmits any shock — straight through, into the floor of his palm, into the small joints of his fingers, into the place where his discipline kept its accounts. He keeps walking. Two meters from her he stops. The blade has not moved from low carry. It is the same matte black blade it was at the start of the night and at the end of it, and the rain runs off it the way rain runs off everything else in this city.

"Drop the weapon," he says.

A half-second where nothing comes. Then her professional register finds its footing, and she

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drops it. The machine pistol clatters on the wet asphalt the way every other piece of hardware on this street has clattered tonight. The street, by Kyle's rough estimate, was now carrying somewhere north of forty thousand credits of dead and broken cyberware between the dog, KT, Rook, and the rifle on the fire escape. The cross-street had not been worth forty thousand credits of anything five minutes ago. The world was, in this small specific way, fucked at exactly the tempo Kyle had ridden in to it on.



Part X: Lotus Wants You

"Lotus wants you on payroll." The machine pistol is on the asphalt between them. She does not look at it. "Full protection envelope. Percentage of every contracted route through our territory. A salary the Pivot would not feel." She says the Pivot the way someone says a word they looked up before they needed it. The NeoCortex catalogs the research. He does not show that he catalogs it. "You said no the first time. I'm asking again."

He does not raise the blade. He lets the rain do what it is going to do to his face. Above them Nines is making a sound that is almost not a sound anymore. The dog's actuators were still trying to cycle the broken jaw emitter at irregular intervals, the chassis ticking at the curb, the kind of mechanical noise that did not need anyone to listen to it but happened regardless.

"No," he says.

She nods. The nod arrives a half-beat after a captain who expected that answer would have produced it. He files the half-beat. She does not press. "Freelance roster, then." Her voice has leveled back into professional register and he gives her credit for the speed of the recovery and nothing else. "Lotus contracts routes through our territory that need a clean face on them. You get first refusal. Carrier rates. No Lotus crew on you in the meantime." She says *in the meantime* the way people say phrases that are doing more work than they appear to be doing. He files that too. The wet asphalt between them held the orange streetlight in long irregular pools and the rain came down between them at the same indifferent rate it had come down the entire engagement, and the arrangement she was

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describing lived in this — two people on a cross-street with a dead woman thirty meters behind them and a man above them spending the last of what the bleed had left him. The math was honest. The freelance roster was the smallest concession this night could end with: his independence formally intact, the audition crews kept off him, the fee structure named plainly, no Lotus brand on anything he did or touched or was. He had spent his life refusing to be anyone's man. The roster was not that. The roster was a door he could close from the inside. What the math did not say — what the math could not say because it did not have access to the full dataset — was that the Syndicate had run fourteen people into him two months ago and lost eight of them and did not stop. Did not stop. He filed the gap. He would not examine it tonight.

Laugh or you'd cry. Kyle laughed quietly, into the inside of his collar, where Mira could not see it. The audition had been an audition. The recruitment was the test result. The test result was: he had passed by killing two of the people who designed the test. Lotus would now compensate him for the two months they had been studying him by hiring him. The world was managed by people who built systems like this and convinced themselves the systems were the only way the work could get done, and Kyle had stopped being the kind of man who argued the point a long time ago. He had become, instead, the kind of man who closed the door from the inside.

"Fixer's name," he says.

"Sable." She says it without hesitation, which means it was ready, which means the name was always part of the offer. "She'll route the contracts."

He nods. The name lands in the place names land. He does not show that it lands. He has known Sable's voice for two months through a cracked terminal, has worked her pipeline cleanly enough that the work has felt routine, and now Lotus is naming her as the routing fixer for his roster spot. The pipeline that has been delivering his contracts is also the pipeline that has been delivering Lotus's. The pipeline has not been advertising this. Sable has not been advertising this. The pipeline has been doing two jobs at once, with one face on, and Kyle is now hearing the second face named for the first time. He files it. He will examine it later. He will examine it carefully. The drawer for tonight's filings is heavy and the bed in 2F is four blocks away and Mira is still standing in the rain waiting for him to walk away from her so the rest of this can be tomorrow's problem.

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He looks at the dog, chassis dark near the sedan, front actuators folded in the particular stillness of drained power rather than destroyed mechanism. He looks at Rook, at the curb, with a leg that did not need to be augmented to be the leg that killed him. He looks at the place on the asphalt where KT's machete fell and made a sound he has still not finished cataloging, and the blade is in his right hand and Nines on the fire escape is quiet now in a way that has stopped being about the bleed. He turns. The wet cross-street opens ahead of him toward the Pivot, toward the cold broth he did not finish, toward whatever the morning was going to ask of him, and he walks.



Part XI: West Erie South

West Erie south. The towers leaned into the cross-street the way they did at every elevation Kyle moved through GLMZ at — the verticality of the city pressing the rain into vertical columns wherever the air had room to move, and at street level the rain was a vertical column of cold percussion through the canyon between The Pivot's block and the residential lattice across from it. His left shoulder registered the bruise in slow pulses, the subdermal mesh having done what it was built to do, which was stop the round and hand the force to the tissue underneath, which was not built for anything in particular. He cataloged it without examining it. The rain had thinned to mist and the mist caught the streetlight in ways that were not interesting and he was grateful for that.

The bike was still where he had left it behind the pharmacy on Ohio. He walked past the alley on his way north, not stopping. He had walked into the cross-street tonight and he would walk out of it. The bike was for the morning. The morning was the morning. The discipline did not have a category for *ride home after killing two people who arranged a six-position ambush to recruit you* and Kyle had decided, somewhere in the last block, that the discipline was correct not to have one.

Mrs. Chen's stall is dark. The fold-down counter is latched. The small propane burner under the left unit is cold — he knows this from three feet away because he knows the smell of it running and this is not that smell. She opens at four. He has two hours on her. He walks

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past and does not slow down and does not look at the counter where the broth he did not finish is not waiting for him. He has thought about the broth twice since the night started and both times he filed it somewhere practical and both times it came back. This is the third time. He does not file it again. He lets it sit in the part of him that is not the hardware and keeps walking.

She made it too hot so he would have to stay.

The Pivot is four blocks. The bio-battery reads fifty-eight percent and cooling. The NeoCortex is running at its ceiling and has been for twenty minutes and he knows what that means the way you know what a soft tire means, which is that it means something and tonight is not the night to examine what. He climbs the stairs to 2F. The lock is there and he does not use it.

Pixel's sleep-suppression protocol comes through the wall at 2E the way her music comes through the wall — not loud, not intrusive, present. He reads the hardware signature without meaning to. BCI at reduced draw, the specific rhythm of a protocol that is managing something rather than ending it, the kind of running-state that means her nights are not quiet enough to sleep through unaided. He has known this for months. He has filed it the way he files exits — not because he plans to use it, because knowing where the exits are is what he does. He sits on the edge of the bed. Silence goes across his thighs in the saya. His right hand holds the hilt because it is where his hand goes when the night is over and he is not yet sure the night is over. The blade is cold against his thigh through the saya, which is the only thing the blade is ever doing when the blade is not cutting anything, which is the part of the discipline he had not, when he was nineteen, expected to find comforting. He had been wrong, at nineteen, about most of the things he had been certain of. The blade being just a sword had been one of them. The shoulder ached in the slow specific way that would be worse tomorrow. The deal sat in the room with him and he did not examine it and it did not leave.

Sable was the fixer. Sable had been the fixer for two months. Sable was now also Lotus's fixer, or had been from the beginning, and the difference between those two readings was the work he was not going to do tonight. The drawer was heavy. The morning was four hours away. The bird upstairs in 3F was doing something with the building's HVAC that Pixel had cataloged as epistemological field-work and Kyle had cataloged as ambient noise,

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and the bird worked overnight the way Pixel worked overnight, and they were each other's companions in a building Kyle now realized he had been living in for four years and which he had stopped, somewhere in the second year, being able to imagine leaving.

He did not sleep. He held the blade across his thighs and listened to the rain and watched the slow gray light start to push at the bottom edge of the window, and the world was still fucked, and tomorrow was still going to be its own day, and the deal sat in the room with him until the slow gray light became the kind of light he could pretend was morning, and he stood up.

Street Meat

Protagonist: Kyle Ellen Corbin-Vister

Act 1: The Contract

The south-arm chamber under the Cruciform Depot is the kind of room that has decided what it is and is not interested in being anything else. Concrete on three sides. Steel on the fourth. A single oak table at the center, two chairs, a bolted-to-the-floor steel chair against the far wall, and on the eastern side a heat rock under a low lamp where a juvenile saltwater crocodile sleeps. Sixty centimeters from snout to tail. The crocodile does not move when Kyle enters. Hua does not look up either. This is the first time Kyle has been in the chamber. He has been on the Lotus freelance roster six weeks — since Mira's interview on the West Town cross-street at oh-two-fourteen on the thirteenth of last month — and has not yet accepted a Lotus-tagged contract through Sable's pipeline. The Lotus side of the roster has accumulated three small unmet routings and zero in-person summons. Tonight Hua summoned him directly, bypassing Sable, which is its own kind of statement. Kyle is here because the summons did not pass through the channel he could refuse it through, and because the math of refusing a personal summons from a south-arm captain after six weeks of polite non-engagement is the math that made the summons necessary in the first place.

The NeoCortex catalogues the chamber in 0.3 seconds: four exits, three of them sealed, the fourth being the one he came in by. No augmented bodies in the room except his own. The crocodile registers in the array's biological-mass scan as an animal of approximately fourteen kilograms whose breathing pattern has not changed in the eleven seconds Kyle has been observing it. The lamp is a sodium-amber, fifteen watts, calibrated to keep the heat rock at thirty-two degrees Celsius. Kyle does not need any of this information. The hardware logs it anyway. The hardware logs everything.

Hua is fifty-something, compact, in a gray qipao that has been pressed that morning. Iron-grey hair cropped close at the sides. No augmentation, which the array confirms with the small absence-flag it produces for unaugmented bodies — the only person in the chamber whose hardware Kyle's array cannot map. She is reading a manila folder at the table. She has been reading it for the eleven seconds Kyle has been observing the crocodile. She finishes a page. Turns it. Finishes another.

She read your file before the meeting. She is reading another file now. The meeting has not

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started yet because she has not decided it has.

When the meeting starts, it starts because she closes the folder. Not because she stands. Not because she gestures. Because the folder is closed. Kyle reads the closing the way he would read a draw. The hardware does not speak.

"Sit, Corbin-Vister. The chair is for the contract. You are not the contract yet."

He sits. The chair across from her is the one for visitors. The bolted chair against the far wall is the one she did not say *yet* about; she said *not yet*. The distinction is tactical. He files it.

She slides a single sheet across the table. The sheet has a manifest code, a payment figure (Φ47,000, half on accept, half on confirmation of delivery), a window (oh-three-hundred to oh-six-hundred, firm), and an address. The address is a corponation facility on the buffer-zone perimeter — Atlas-program continuation lab, Helix-subcontracted intake. He has run two extractions inside facilities of this taxonomy before. The taxonomy is on the page. The cargo is not.

He reads the sheet. He looks up.

"Cargo."

"A person. Researcher held under corporate constraint at the facility's research wing. Designated by the manifest code on the sheet. Cell 4-East, intake-zone-three. Ambulatory. Cooperative when the door opens — they have been told to expect an extraction tonight, they have not been told who. They will walk out of the cell under their own power once you are in the corridor with them."

"Name."

"Manifest code is the identifier I am giving you."

"Name."

Hua does not look up. "I am not naming the cargo. The cargo is the manifest code. Take the contract on the manifest code or do not take the contract."

She is withholding the name. She has never withheld the name on a contract before. The withholding is information. Acting on it is also information.

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He does not act on it. The hardware runs the read on Hua's micro-expressions: the brow symmetry, the lip line, the small stillness around the eyes that belongs to people who have stopped performing. She is not lying about anything she has said. She is not telling him what she has not said. The two facts coexist the way they coexist with operators of her caliber — she has decided what to disclose and what to withhold, and the withholding is part of the contract design, and Kyle has known this about Hua's reputation since long before he ever sat across a table from her, because Hua's reputation is exactly the contract-designer reputation that produced the freelance roster offer at the cross-street six weeks ago. The withholding is the price of the roster being valuable. He has accepted that price in principle for six weeks.

Tonight the price has come due in person, and he is not certain the math holds. He files the uncertainty. He does not raise it.

"Why."

"Because if I tell you the name, your code refuses the contract before you walk out of this chamber, and the cargo dies in the research wing at oh-six-hundred. The cargo is alive at oh-six-hundred only if you take the contract on the code I am offering. I am not asking you to like the trade. I am offering you the trade. Take it or do not take it."

The hardware files this as the cleanest description Hua has ever given of how she works. Kyle hears it the way you hear a thesis. He does not let his face show the filing.

She is telling you she knows your code. The telling is itself part of the contract design. She is buying your acceptance of the withholding by being honest about why she is withholding. The honesty is the trap. You see the trap. You are taking the contract anyway because the alternative is the cargo dying at oh-six-hundred, and the code does not have a clause that prefers a closed file at oh-six-hundred over a person walking out under your custody at oh-five-forty-five.

The code does not have that clause. Kyle reads the rest of the sheet.

"Why me."

"You have completed three extractions from Helix-subcontracted Atlas-program continuation labs in the last twelve months. Two of them were facilities of the same security

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taxonomy as this one. Your reputation in this part of the work reaches farther than your roster file. The cargo will be in the cell at oh-three-twenty. The bay-three loading dock has its outbound window at oh-five-fifteen until oh-five-forty-five — that is your egress geometry, the rest of the bays roll on facility schedules I cannot adjust. The entry, the egress transport, and the routing to the rendezvous are your problem. I am not paying for the method. I am paying for the cargo at the rendezvous on the sheet at oh-six-hundred."

The hardware runs the math on what she has just said. The math is correct. Three extractions in twelve months, two of them at this taxonomy — Hua reads contracts the way she reads files, and the volume of Atlas-program-adjacent work he has been doing through Sable's pipeline lately is the kind of pattern that surfaces in any roster captain's quarterly review. She has not named the methods he used on the previous three. She does not need to. The pattern is the pattern. He is the freelancer she trusts to figure out an Atlas-program continuation lab's intake protocol because he has figured one out three times this year.

"Egress."

"Bay three rolls outbound at oh-five-fifteen until oh-five-forty-five, as I said — that is your geometry. After that the bay closes for the morning shift and the next scheduled outbound is at oh-eight-twenty, which is past your window for the cargo's window. You arrange whatever you arrange to receive the cargo at bay three before oh-five-forty-five. After that the contract is on the someone else and the someone else is going to be expensive."

Kyle does not respond. The hardware is already running the entry problem in parallel with the conversation. Helix-subcontracted Atlas-program continuation lab. The taxonomy is what he has run twice this year. Their perimeter is intake-grade, not active-pursuit-grade — the security model assumes nobody breaks *into* a place that processes the dead. The intake channel is calibrated for unaugmented donor bodies and Atlas-program specimens; the scanners flag tampering, not presence. An Atlas-program subject arriving as a corpse will be tagged as routine intake, processed through the cold-chain channel, and routed to a holding bay for autopsy queue. The holding bay is contiguous with the research wing. A walking subject from the holding bay to the research wing does not generate an alarm because the research wing's staff routinely move between the two. The exit through bay three is the standard outbound for processed material. The math resolves in 0.6 seconds.

The False Death Protocol. The protocol is exactly what this facility's intake is calibrated to

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process without flagging. Atlas-program-subject corpse arriving via Vultures specimen-intake → holding bay slab → restart at the 240-second mark → walk to the cargo's cell through the research wing → exit through bay three with the cargo at the driver's window. The math is not complicated. The math is also costly. The protocol is the thing you do not advertise. The protocol is the thing you have used three times in your life, none of them recently, all of them in private. You are about to use it for a fourth.

The hardware files the calculation. Kyle does not say *False Death Protocol* aloud. The protocol's existence is in his Atlas Division medical file and nowhere else, and the thing the protocol is most useful for is the thing it is most useful for *if no one knows you have it*. He has not advertised the protocol because the protocol's value is its invisibility. He is not going to advertise it now to a Lotus Syndicate captain who reads files for a living. He will arrange the Vultures pickup himself through his own contact at the federation's western dispatch node — a man named Dax who has driven two of his deliveries before, who does not ask questions, who will pick him up in an unmarked panel van at the alley behind the recycler substation Kyle has used as a rendezvous twice this year.

He says, neutral: "Acknowledged. The entry will be in place by oh-three-twenty."

Hua does not look up. "That is not a confirmation of method."

"You said you were not paying for the method."

"I am not. I am noting that you also did not specify it."

"That is correct."

Hua turns a page. "Thank you for not specifying it. The fewer people who know what you are about to do, the fewer people who can route the information past me by accident. I appreciate operators who do not advertise."

The hardware logs the sentence. The sentence is precise. The sentence does not say *I do not know what you are about to do*. The sentence says *the fewer people who know, the fewer who can route past me*. Hua may know. Hua may not know. The sentence is calibrated to be true either way. He files it. He does not act on it.

"Risks."

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"Within parameters. The cargo will not resist extraction. The cargo has been told to expect you. The facility's security is intake-grade, not active-pursuit-grade. The exit window is the firm window. The driver is reliable."

Reliable is what she calls things she has already paid for in advance. The cargo has been told to expect you. The cargo will be ready.

He has the question in his head. He has had it since the moment Hua refused the name. The question is the question every operator in his line of work has to ask before accepting a withheld-cargo contract: *what kind of person is the cargo*. The kind of question that gets asked obliquely because the asking-directly costs something. Kyle has accepted withheld-cargo contracts twice in seven years. Both times the withholding was protective tradecraft — the contractor did not know the name in order to not be able to give it up under interrogation. Both times the cargo turned out to be exactly what Hua's framing implied. He is going to assume the same is true here because the assumption is the only assumption the contract permits him to make. He is also going to be wrong about it. The hardware does not yet know this. Neither does he.

He says: "Φ47,000 is below the rate for an extraction of a held researcher from an Atlas-program continuation lab. The standard would be sixty-five."

"The standard is sixty-five."

"Φ47 is a discount."

"Yes."

"Why."

Hua picks up the folder again. Opens it. Does not look up. "Because the contract is the contract. The price is the price. Take it or do not take it. The driver is at oh-two-hundred either way; if you do not take it I find someone else who can solve the entry, and the someone else will charge me the full sixty-five and run a forty percent failure probability, and I will pay it and absorb the failure, and the cargo will be a closed file by oh-six-hundred. The Φ18,000 discount is what you save me if I do not have to use the someone else."

The arithmetic is correct. The arithmetic is also designed. Kyle has not been in this room before, but he has been across desks and tables from operators of Hua's caliber for years,

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and he recognizes the shape of being told a true thing for a designed reason without needing prior in-person experience with this specific operator.

She is telling you the truth because the truth is the trap. The trap is not the contract. The trap is the withholding. She bought your discipline by not telling you what you are discipline-ing toward.

The hardware files this. Kyle does not act on it.

He takes the sheet. He folds it once. He puts it in the inside pocket of the jacket. He does not say *accepted*. The taking is the accepting. Hua has not looked up since she opened the folder the second time. The crocodile has not moved. The chamber is the chamber.

At the door, before he leaves, she says — without looking up — "Thank you for your time."

It is the first sentence she has said in eleven years that has felt to him like a conclusion.



Act 2: The Vultures

The rendezvous is a service alley behind a recycler substation in the buffer zone. Kyle is there at oh-one-fifty-three. He has eaten — not at Mrs. Chen's, somewhere else, somewhere he can be unrecognized — a high-fat protein bar and two ounces of pure glucose paste, the kind of meal the False Death Protocol's restart curve responds to. The Cerebral Oxygenation Assist is at full reserve. The bio-battery is at sixty-two percent and climbing — as high as it will go without a hot meal he does not have time for. He has run the protocol three times in his life. None of them have been pleasant. The third was a controlled training event at Seo's insistence. Seo had stood beside the table the whole four minutes. Kyle is not running this one in front of anyone he trusts.

The Vultures truck arrives at oh-one-fifty-eight. Unmarked panel van, refrigerated, the Carrion Logistics LLC insignia in matte black on the left chest of the driver's gray uniform when he steps out — a tall man, mid-forties, no augmentation Kyle's array can detect, the bored efficiency of someone who has done this several times tonight already. He does not

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greet Kyle. He opens the back of the van. The interior is what Kyle expected: refrigerated cabin, four body-length compartments, two of them currently occupied with bodies the Vultures have been collecting on tonight's route. The driver gestures to the empty compartment second from the bay door. Kyle climbs in. The driver hands him a tag — a small adhesive strip with a barcode and a manifest number, the same manifest number from Hua's sheet. Kyle peels the backing and applies the tag to his own left wrist where the intake scanner will read it.

"Six minutes to the facility," the driver says. He does not look at Kyle. "You'll go through intake while you're under. Wake up on the slab in the holding bay. The slab will be at thirty-eight degrees. Don't sit up immediately — give the scanners ninety seconds to log you as ambient before you move. After that, you have approximately two and a half minutes before the next intake clerk's rotation. Bay three is the loading dock you want. The loading dock door is forty-six meters from the holding bay's southern exit."

Kyle looks at him. "You have done this before."

"Six times. The last one made it. The five before that did too. No one I have driven has yet failed to wake up. I do not know if the protocol fails sometimes; I only know that for me it has not."

"That is not statistically meaningful."

"No, it is not. But you should hear it before you stop your heart."

Kyle nods. The driver closes the back of the van. The interior is dark and cold. Kyle settles against the compartment wall, draws his knees up, places the tip of his right thumb at the precise interface point on his cardiac regulator at the left lateral throat, and runs the False Death Protocol's NeoCortex signal sequence.

The sequence is twenty-two characters long. He memorized it at sixteen. He has not used it in two years. The hardware recognizes it the way a lock recognizes a key.

Three. Two.

The regulator crashes into safe-mode flatline at the *one*. The Cerebral Oxygenation Assist activates at the *zero*. Kyle's heart stops. The 240-second timer begins. The world is not pain exactly. The world is the sound of his own pulse going away, and then the sound of his own

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pulse not being there to listen for, and then a quiet so specific it is not even quiet, it is just the absence of the frequency he has been listening to for twenty-seven years.

The last thing the hardware logs before the bio-battery routes to the assist is the truck's engine, cycling up, pulling away from the alley.

Then nothing.



He wakes on the slab.

The ceiling above him is low — institutional drop-tile, fluorescent panels, one panel flickering at a frequency the hardware logs as 47Hz, which is the frequency Helix-subcontracted facilities run their secondary lighting at. The slab is at thirty-eight degrees as the driver said it would be. Kyle does not move. The hardware runs the diagnostic: bio-battery at fifty-one percent (the protocol cost ten and a half), cardiac regulator restarted on the documented schedule, Cerebral Oxygenation Assist returning to standby with three minutes thirty seconds of reserve unused, all sensor channels nominal. He counts to ninety. He does not move. The 47Hz panel flickers above him. Somewhere out of his sightline, an intake scanner cycles a soft chime — his ambient logging, the body's heat signature finally registering as living-and-not-anomalous. The chime resolves into the silence of a room a building has decided is empty. He sits up.

The holding bay is small — four slabs in the row he is on, two in another row at right angles, all of them empty except his own. The walls are the same drop-tile as the ceiling. The lighting is low and clinical. There is one door at the southern wall, closed, and the door has the thin red diode that means it is sealed pending intake-clerk authorization. He has approximately two and a half minutes before the rotation. The bay is empty of people. The cargo is not here. The cargo is in Cell 4-East, intake-zone-three, which the facility's standard schematic places approximately eighty meters east through the maintenance corridor and into the research wing.

Kyle works the lock-override on the southern door with the pry bar and the wire from the small bag he tied at his belt before the protocol. The kit the Vultures' driver did not inspect

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because Vultures drivers do not inspect anything. The lock cycles in nine seconds. The diode goes from red to green. He pulls the small adhesive tag off his left wrist and crushes the barcode under his thumb until the strip cracks. The tag is now unreadable. The intake log will mark him as either a tampered-tag specimen or as departed-without-clearance. Either way, the next intake clerk's rotation is going to find a problem. He has between two and three minutes before that becomes his problem too.

He opens the door. The maintenance corridor is empty.



The corridor is the standard Helix-subcontracted secondary-site geometry — narrow, low ceilings, the institutional gray of a building that has decided color is a maintenance cost it would rather not pay. The hardware overlays the schematic the array harvested from the badge-reader frequency three hours ago against the actual geometry as Kyle moves. The two match within tolerances. He is forty-six meters from the eastern junction where the corridor branches into the research wing. The research wing is where Cell 4-East is. The research wing is also where the on-shift staff are — a low-density night cycle, four people across two floors per Helix's standard staffing model, three of them in the lab on the upper floor, one of them on patrol rotation at the lower-floor desk. The lower-floor desk is between Kyle and Cell 4-East.

He moves. He moves the way he has moved through corridors at this taxonomy three times this year — efficient, low, the array tracking the patrol officer's electromagnetic signature through the wall before Kyle is in the wall's adjacent corridor. The signature is at the desk. The signature is stationary. The signature has been stationary for at least the duration of Kyle's last forty meters of approach, which means the officer is reading something or eating something or sleeping something off, and any of those answers to the geometry question is acceptable.

The desk comes around a corner. The officer is reading. He does not see Kyle until Kyle is two meters from the desk. The hardware reads the draw the moment the officer's hand twitches toward the holster — Ballistic Precognition firing passive, the read arriving at Kyle's body 0.4 seconds before the officer's hand finishes the motion — and Kyle's body is

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already moving, already past the line where the round will be, already at the officer's side with the joint-lock at the wrist and the pressure release at the brachial plexus. The officer folds. Kyle catches him before the body hits the floor (the catching is acoustic, not kindness — a body hitting institutional flooring is louder than the discipline can afford), zip-ties the wrists to the leg of the desk, and is past the desk and into the research wing's main corridor in under nine seconds.

Cell 4-East is at the end of the row. The corridor is empty. The cells along the corridor are mostly dark — the wing operates on a research staff's day-shift cycle, most of its occupants sedated or sleeping at this hour. Cell 4-East has a low light burning behind the viewport. The light is not the cell's overhead. The light is something the cell's occupant has on at oh-three-twenty in the morning because the cell's occupant is awake and is reading something.

Kyle works the cell's lock with the pry bar and the wire. Nine seconds.

The door opens.

She is forty-three. Compact. Korean — monocultural Korean, the array confirms before Kyle's conscious thought finishes the sentence, ninety-nine percent ancestry by the array's phenotype-read at the resolution it can run at fifty-one percent bio-battery, the rare and statistically improbable kind of monoculture that registers in the GLMZ as anomaly before it registers as person. Black hair short, threaded with the first iron-grey at the temples. Glasses with thin metal frames. Plain dark cotton long-sleeve top. Surgical-grade hands holding a small leather case in her lap. She is sitting on the bunk reading a printed journal under a lamp she has clipped to the bunk's frame because the cell's overhead is on the night-low setting. She looks up.

Phenotype confirmed before person was named. The catalogue order is information. You do not have time to examine which kind.

She closes the journal. She sets it on the bunk. She picks up the leather case and stands. The motion is unhurried. She has been told to expect an extraction tonight — Hua said so on the sheet, *the cargo has been told to expect you* — and she is responding to the door opening the way you respond to a thing you have been told would happen. She does not look surprised. She does not look afraid. She looks at Kyle the way she would look at a colleague she does not yet know but has been told to cooperate with.

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"You are early," she says. American-academic English with the precise geometry of a non-native speaker who learned the language as the medium of her profession. "They told me oh-three-thirty."

"We are leaving," Kyle says. He has not yet given his name. He is not going to. Hua's manifest code is on the cell's external tag and Kyle has matched it against the sheet and the matching is the only credential the contract requires. "Now."

"Yes," she says. She tucks the leather case under her left arm. She steps out of the cell. She closes the door behind her — a small, precise motion, the door pulled to the latch but not locked, the kind of leaving-tidy that someone does when they do not want the people coming to look for them in the morning to immediately know which way they went. The hardware files this. He does not comment.

They start back down the corridor at a measured walk. She matches his pace within two steps. The eastern junction is forty meters ahead. The bay-three loading dock is sixty meters past the junction.

They make it twenty meters before the second patrol officer comes around the eastern junction's far corner.

This one has been on the second-floor lab and is descending — the array reads the descent because the second-floor staircase exits into the same junction the cell corridor opens onto, and the descending body has the specific motor signature of someone who knows the building and is moving with intent toward the lower-floor desk where the first officer was supposed to be. He sees Kyle first. He sees the cell tag on the wall behind Kyle's shoulder second. He sees the doctor third. The hardware times the reads: 0.2 seconds, 0.3 seconds, 0.4 seconds. Total recognition window: 0.9 seconds.

The officer's right hand moves toward the holster. Augmented, this one — chrome-laced reflex augment at the right temple, the array catalogues it, the augment's motor-bus spike is measurable as a clean electromagnetic bloom 0.3 seconds before the hand finishes its motion. Ballistic Precognition fires passive. The read arrives at Kyle's body before the officer's body knows what its body is about to do.

Kyle steps left and forward — not back, into the angle the round will not occupy — and the officer fires, and the shot goes through the space Kyle's chest was occupying 0.3 seconds

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ago, and the round hits the wall behind him, and Kyle is already inside the officer's reach with the pry bar against the chrome bracket at the temple. One precise contact. The reflex augment shorts. The officer's draw arm goes loose, the second shot does not come, and Kyle puts him on the floor with a knee to the back of the leg and zip-ties the wrists to the corner brace of the junction wall.

Eleven seconds. Both officers down. Forty meters to bay three.

He turns to the doctor.

She is two meters back, where she stopped when the first round fired. The leather case is still under her left arm. Her right hand is at her mouth — not in the gesture of someone who is about to scream, in the gesture of someone who has just witnessed a thing she has read about in journals. The pupils are dilated. The breath is the small involuntary intake at the back of the throat. She is not looking at the officer on the floor. She is looking at Kyle.

She lowers the hand. The voice is small, controlled, the cadence of a person composing the sentence in real time as the sentence forms.

"Ballistic Precognition... Incredible." she gasped.

The word she uses is the program's internal designation. She does not use the marketing name. She does not use the consumer-grade colloquialism. She uses the term Atlas Division put on the intake forms and the discharge summaries and the trial-protocol documents that Kyle has not seen since he was seventeen. The capability she just named was the one she filed under *theoretical at this density* because the only people she had ever seen run it were dead. She is not naming the capability. She is *recognizing* it. The recognition comes from a specific place. The specific place has a specific name.

The hardware files her. The filing is instant. The cognitive baseline implant at her left mastoid (Atlas Division employment badge, dormant, unrevoked) which the array had registered when the cell door opened and which Kyle had not yet examined because there had not been time to examine it. The surgical-grade dexterity profile. The way she had stood from the bunk — settled into the geometry of someone who has spent twenty years bent over operating tables. The leather case — the calibration toolchain, Kyle recognizes it now from the photographs Atlas Division never let leak. The age. The monocultural Korean phenotype. The English that learned itself as the medium of her profession.

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She is the doctor. She is ex-NeoCortex Atlas Division. She walked off the program and has been salaried-silent for two years and the silence was about to end because Hua hired Kyle to deliver her to Hua, and Hua did not name her because Hua had read his file and Hua knew that if she had named the cargo as an Atlas Division surgeon, Kyle's code would have refused the contract before he walked out of Hua's chamber.

Kyle does not move. The officer at his feet is unconscious. The corridor behind the doctor is empty. The corridor ahead of them is empty. They have approximately four minutes before the upper-floor lab notices the missing patrol officer and routes a check.

The arithmetic resolves in 0.4 seconds.

The contract requires you to deliver this woman to Hua of the Lotus Syndicate. The code requires you not to deliver her to Hua of the Lotus Syndicate. The code wins. The code always wins. The contract is now a contract you will complete only the extraction half of. The delivery is going to be to Sable, off-GLMZ, by oh-eight-hundred. You will refund Hua's half-payment afterward and walk back into her chamber to close the contract from your side, because the code requires the closing. You will go in the chair for the closing. The chair is the cost. The cost is named. The cost is acceptable.

The arithmetic is complete in 0.4 seconds. Kyle does not let his face show the arithmetic. The doctor is still looking at him.

"Doctor," he says. The first word he has said to her with the title acknowledged. "We are leaving. Now."

She nods. The dilated pupils stabilize. The hand goes back to the leather case. The discipline she has been keeping for ten years engages and she becomes immediately competent again.

"Bay three," she says. "Sixty meters. Permitted route through the maintenance corridor. I have walked it twice."

"Walked."

"They permit me certain perimeter freedoms within the wing. I have been logged as cooperative."

"Then you are going to walk it a third time."

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They go.



The maintenance corridor is sixty meters as the doctor said. They walk it in just under a minute. The bay-three loading dock door is unsealed at this hour because the bay is in active use — a Vultures truck Kyle does not recognize is in bay one offloading, two delivery clerks are in bay two with a refrigerated pallet, and bay three is empty except for the small panel van Kyle's contact at the federation's western dispatch node has parked there. Dax. The same tall man, mid-forties, unaugmented, who picked Kyle up at the recycler-substation alley three hours ago and delivered Kyle's flatlined body to the facility's specimen-intake channel and has now circled back per the second half of the schedule Kyle filed at oh-one-forty-five — a federation egress, federation rate, no Lotus routing in the paperwork. Dax leans against the van with a hand-rolled smoke and the same bored efficiency he had at the alley. Dax has driven two of Kyle's deliveries before. Dax does not ask questions.

Kyle walks Doctor Park toward the van. Dax sees them. Dax registers Doctor Park — that the cargo is ambulatory, walking out under her own power, with a leather case and a freelancer at her elbow. Dax registers, in the way Vultures drivers register everything, that this is a different shape of cargo than the contract sheet specified at the western-dispatch desk three hours ago. Dax puts the smoke out under his boot.

"Change of route," Kyle says. He does not slow down. He has Doctor Park by the elbow now, gentle, the doctor walking at his pace because she has decided to. "Drop us at the West Town safehouse instead of the rendezvous. Federation rate, plus the difference."

Dax looks at him for a count of four. The hardware times it. Dax does the math the same way a Vulture driver does the math: the federation contract Kyle filed at oh-one-forty-five specified an egress destination Kyle now wants changed; the change costs Dax nothing the original schedule was paying him because the original schedule was Kyle's federation contract end-to-end; the change gains him the difference Kyle is offering against the West Town safehouse routing; the math is *which rate Kyle is paying on the way back, and whether the cargo fits the original specification*. The cargo is ambulatory rather than refrigerated. The federation has standing language for ambulatory cargo. The standing

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language is more expensive than refrigerated. Kyle is offering federation rate plus the difference. Dax is a federation driver. The math is not neutral.

Dax opens the back of the van.

"West Town safehouse," he says. "Forty-three minutes. I will not stop for anything."

Kyle helps Doctor Park into the back. The doctor does not say anything. The doctor takes the bench seat near the cab, sets the leather case on her lap, and folds her hands over it. Kyle sits across from her. Dax closes the back. The van pulls out. The bay-three loading dock fades behind them. The hardware runs the timeline: oh-three-thirty-two when they leave the dock, oh-four-fifteen at the West Town safehouse, oh-four-thirty if Sable can route a pickup. Kyle opens the encrypted relay.

Sable answers in two seconds.

"Kyle."

"I have her. The cargo is the doctor — Park, ex-Atlas, the one I have been looking for. I am bringing her to the West Town safehouse. I need you there in thirty minutes. She is going off-GLMZ tonight."

The pause is one second. Sable does not waste pauses. "Off-GLMZ where."

"Wherever you can put her that no one in Lotus can reach."

Another second. Kyle hears the small mechanical sound of her ocular implants adjusting — she is reading the data feed in real time, recalculating the routes, the safehouses, the pickups, the favors, the whole map.

"I can put her on the Pulse at oh-five-twenty out of Lakeshore Terminal. Rotterdam in forty-three minutes. From Rotterdam I can route her into a free-floating sector by oh-eight-hundred. Total cost to my network: significant. Total cost to you: a favor I will name later."

"Take it."

"Done. I will be at the West Town safehouse in twenty-eight minutes."

The relay closes. Kyle looks at Doctor Park. Doctor Park is looking at him with the precise expression she had when she lowered her hand from the corridor wall — the researcher

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waiting for a result. He does not say anything. There is nothing to say yet. The van turns onto the buffer-zone arterial. The hardware cycles down to the diagnostic baseline. The bio-battery climbs.

You did not deliver. The code held. The contract is broken. The contract being broken is the contract Hua designed for. She wins on every fork. You are picking which of her wins she gets, and the one you are picking is the one with the chair.

Kyle knows this. He has known this since the moment the doctor named the read in the corridor. He keeps not saying anything. The doctor cleans her glasses on the hem of her shirt. The van runs.



Act 3: The Pivot

The West Town safehouse is the side door at The Pivot — Kyle's building, his floor, his unit. He has not had the doctor anywhere else. The driver drops them at the alley entrance at oh-four-eleven, drives away without looking back, and Kyle takes Doctor Park up the back stairs and unlocks 2F and lets her in. He sets the chain on the door behind them.

The doctor stands in the middle of the room. She does not sit down. She catalogues the unit the way Kyle would catalogue a room: medkit by the door, notebook on the counter, the photograph of his mother on the windowsill facing the intersection because she would have wanted to see the street, the friction sheath for the katana on the hook beside the kitchen archway, the specific sparseness of a person who lives alone and has made decisions about what he will keep. She looks at the photograph for slightly longer than the rest. She does not comment.

Kyle goes across the hall to 2E and knocks.

Pixel opens it on the third knock. She is in the oversized sweater and the steel-toed boots even at oh-four-fifteen — the boots on means she has been working, the sweater means it is cold in the unit, the absence of music means she is concentrating. She takes one look at Kyle and says, level, the way she always says it: "What is in the apartment."

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"A doctor. Ex-NeoCortex Atlas Division. I need her safe for fifteen minutes until Sable picks her up."

"Why is she here and not in your safehouse."

"This is my safehouse."

"Kyle. This is your *home*."

"Yes."

Pixel looks at him for one full second. She does not perform the look — it is the calibration look, the one she uses when she is checking whether his hardware is the thing producing the decision. She decides it is not. She picks up the small toolkit she keeps by the door and she walks across the hall ahead of him.

In 2F, Doctor Park is at the kitchen counter, the leather case on the counter beside her, looking out the small kitchen window at the street. Pixel comes in. Pixel looks at the doctor. The doctor looks at Pixel.

The phenotype read on Pixel registers Northern European 57 / Eastern European 28 / Southern European 15 — a face the GLMZ would describe as legibly pale. The phenotype read on the doctor registers Korean 99 — a face the GLMZ has not seen in years. The doctor has just been read in 0.4 seconds. The doctor knows she has been read. The reading is mutual.

"Hi," Pixel says. The brightness is not real. The brightness is a calibrated weapon. "I am Pixel. I live across the hall. I am Kyle's neighbor and the person who maintains his hardware and the person who calibrated the lateral-array thermal-stress markers two weeks ago that he has not addressed yet."

The doctor cleans her glasses on the hem of her shirt. She puts the glasses back on. She nods. "Park Na-Young," she says. "Nadia. I am the person Kyle was contracted to deliver to a Lotus Syndicate captain tonight. He decided not to. He is now a person who has decided not to deliver me to a Lotus Syndicate captain, which is the kind of decision that has consequences I do not yet know the full shape of. I am told I will be picked up shortly."

"Yes," Pixel says, and the brightness is now openly hostile, "by Sable, who is a fixer who

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routes contracts and who I have known longer than you have. I suppose you are going to tell me you can do something about the lateral-array thermal-stress markers I have not yet addressed because I am, what was it, a girl with a soldering iron and you are a credentialed neurosurgeon."

The doctor looks at Pixel. The doctor does not perform the look. She looks the way she would look at an electrode array she is reviewing for calibration. Her glasses do not need cleaning again. She cleans them anyway.

"I would not phrase it that way," the doctor says. "You have done good work with bad documentation. The lateral-array drift you flagged two weeks ago is a firmware issue, not a hardware issue. Whoever calibrated him last did the right thing with the wrong tool. The correction is documented in a manual the program never released and that I happen to have memorized. If Kyle ever needs the manual, I can write it out. The work you have done since the last calibration has been creative. *Creative* is the word the program used for what someone does when they do not have access to the documentation but produce the right outcome anyway. It is a compliment. I do not know how to phrase it so that it does not sound condescending. I am sorry for that. I have spent a lot of years in rooms where the only register I had was the technical one."

Pixel stares at her.

Then Pixel turns to Kyle.

"She is being *gracious* at me," Pixel says, and the word *gracious* is an indictment, "and I cannot find anywhere to land the response. She is too good at this. I am going to need three days to figure out how to be properly angry about this and I do not have three days. Kyle, why is this happening in my building."

"Because the building is also my building," Kyle says, and he means it as a deflection, but it lands as a fact, and Pixel registers the fact, and the doctor registers Pixel registering the fact, and the room re-balances itself in the small way rooms re-balance when three people who have not previously been in the same room at the same time decide who is in charge of which silence.

The doctor sets her leather case on Kyle's small kitchen table. "While we are waiting," she says, "would you like me to look at the lateral array."

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Kyle says: "No."

The doctor nods. "That is the correct answer at this time. There is a long answer about why you would benefit from saying yes eventually, and a different long answer about why you should not say yes tonight, and we do not have time for either. I am not going to press. I am going to put the case back in my hand." She picks the case up. She returns to the counter. She does not look at Pixel again, but she does say, in the same level voice: "I would have done good work with what you have. I am glad he has had it. I am leaving in approximately eleven minutes. The arrangement is not permanent. The work you have been doing is keeping him alive. I would like that to continue."

Pixel does not respond. Pixel cannot respond, because the only response available is gratitude or rage and she will not perform either in front of the doctor, and the doctor knows this, and the doctor is using the knowing the way a researcher uses a known variable. Kyle sees Pixel decide to file the encounter for later examination and to exit the room while she still can.

Pixel exits the room. She closes the door behind her.

In the hallway outside 2F, Pixel says — quietly, the way she says things when she does not want them to count as said — "I hate her so much."

Kyle, on the inside of the door, hears her. He does not respond. The doctor is at the counter cleaning her glasses again. The doctor heard too. The doctor is pretending she did not.

Pixel is not wrong. Pixel is also not right. The doctor is what the doctor is, and the doctor has not done anything wrong. Pixel knows this. The hatred is the kind that forms when the world produces a person who is what you would be if your life had gone differently and they happen to be in your building at four in the morning. File it. Do not act on it. There is not time.

There is not time. Sable arrives at oh-four-twenty-eight, which is six minutes earlier than her stated estimate, which is the kind of margin Sable arranges when the math is tight. She comes up the back stairs in the tan coat with her hands in the pockets and her ocular implants adjusting to the unit's lighting and her face composed in the precise stillness of a fixer who has decided that the next fifteen minutes are the most expensive fifteen minutes of her quarter. She does not knock; Kyle has the door open before she reaches it. She steps

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inside. She looks at the doctor.

"Doctor Park," she says.

"Sable," the doctor says. "I have been told to expect you."

"You have been told correctly. We have nineteen minutes to be at Lakeshore Terminal. Pulse 0520 to Rotterdam. From Rotterdam I have a route to a destination I will not name in this room. The destination is reasonable. You will not be comfortable. You will be unfindable."

The doctor nods. She picks up the leather case. She looks at Kyle.

"Thank you," she says.

Kyle does not say *you are welcome*. He does not have a category for what to say. The hardware does not produce a recommendation. He nods. He does not look away from her. She cleans her glasses one more time on the hem of her shirt and she follows Sable to the door.

At the door, Sable stops. She looks back at Kyle. She does not perform the look — she just looks, the implants logging him at the resolution she runs at when she has decided to remember a thing.

"Hua is going to know within the hour," Sable says.

"I know."

"You are going back."

"Yes."

"Why."

Kyle thinks about the answer for a half-second. The hardware does not have an answer. The code has the answer. The code does not articulate well in language. He says:

"Because the contract is the contract. Hua paid me at half. I am going to give her her money back. The contract is going to close from my side because that is the only side it can close from now."

Sable looks at him. The implants make their small adjustment. She does not say *do not go*.

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She has known him long enough to know that *do not go* is not a sentence he hears.

She says: "I will take care of her."

"I know."

The door closes behind them. The unit is quiet. The doctor's leather case is gone. The kitchen is the kitchen. The photograph of his mother is on the windowsill facing the intersection. Kyle stands in the middle of the room. The hardware diagnostic resumes its baseline cycle.

Pixel.

Kyle goes across the hall and knocks on 2E.

Pixel opens it on the first knock. She has been standing at the door. She has heard Sable arrive and Sable leave. She knows what is coming because she has known what is coming since the moment Kyle said *this is my safehouse*.

"Don't go," Pixel says.

"I have to."

"You don't."

"I do."

"Kyle. Hua does not require you to bring the money back. The contract was paid at half. If you do not bring the money back, she calls in the half she paid as a debt and it accrues, and you owe her, and that is bad. If you do bring the money back, you are walking into her chamber having just refused her contract, and she puts you in the chair. The chair, Kyle. The actual chair. The one that is bolted to the floor. The one that — " Pixel stops herself. The breath is shaking in the way her breath shakes when she is trying not to perform the shaking. "I have looked at the casualty patterns from every freelancer who has refused a Lotus contract in the last four years. The pattern is the chair. The pattern is hands. The pattern is — "

"Pixel."

" — Kyle. The pattern is *hands*."

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"Pixel. I know."

She looks at him. Her face does the thing it does when she is processing — the small flicker of the eyes as the catalogue runs — and then she looks at his hands. He still has them. They are at his sides. The hardware logs Pixel looking at them. He does not move them.

"You know," she says.

"Yes."

"And you are going."

"Yes."

"Why."

"Because the code is the code. Because if I do not close the contract from my side, Hua holds the half-payment as a debt, and the debt sits as ambient leverage that ages without spending, and I will spend the next two years not knowing when she calls it. If I close the contract — refund the money, walk in, walk out — the debt is settled at the cost of whatever she chooses to do to me when I walk in. The cost will be high. It will not be infinite. The debt would be infinite. I am picking the lower cost."

Pixel closes her eyes. "You are picking the cost that takes your hands."

"I am picking the cost I can name."

"Kyle."

"Pixel. I know."

She opens her eyes. She looks at him. She does not cry. She has not cried in front of him in three years and she is not going to start now, because the not-crying is part of the convention they have built, and the convention is the only thing keeping either of them upright at this hour. She nods. The nod is small. The nod is acceptance. The nod is the most expensive nod Pixel has ever given him.

"Come back," she says.

"I will try."

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"Try harder than that."

"I will."

She steps back. She closes the door. He hears the lock cycle. He hears her take three steps away from the door inside the unit and stop. He stands in the hall for two seconds. Then he goes back to 2F. He picks up Silence from the hook by the kitchen archway. He settles the friction sheath across his back. He picks up the credit chip from the kitchen drawer — the half-payment Hua gave him three hours ago, untouched, the chip still in the evidence sleeve the syndicate banker put it in. He puts the chip in the inside pocket of the jacket where Hua's manifest sheet lives.

He leaves 2F. He locks the door. He goes down the back stairs.

The rain is still going. Outside the alley, the GLMZ is in the small hours where the city pretends to sleep. Kyle walks south toward the Cruciform Depot. He does not call Sable. He does not call Pixel. He does not call anyone. The chip is in his pocket. The blade is on his back. The code is the code.



Act 4: The Refund

The south-arm chamber is exactly as it was at oh-one-twenty when he sat down across from Hua and took the contract. The crocodile is on the heat rock. The lamp is at fifteen watts. The folding chair is bolted to the floor against the far wall. Hua is at the table reading a different folder this time. She closes it when Kyle steps through the door. She does not say *sit*.

There are two of her men against the eastern wall now. There were not at oh-one-twenty. Both of them have augmented forearms and the small twitch at the right temple that marks reflex augments at full draw. The senior lieutenant — the one who has been with her twenty years, the one she asks about his mother every Tuesday — is at the door behind Kyle, between Kyle and the only exit. Kyle's array catalogues all three before his foot has finished the third step into the room.

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Kyle takes the chip out of his pocket. He walks to the table. He sets the chip on the table in front of Hua. He stays standing.

"Standard rate," he says. The voice is the voice he has practiced for a long time. "Refunded."

Hua looks at the chip. She does not pick it up.

The arithmetic resolves in his interior, in the silence the chamber has trained itself to hold. The hardware is not the thing that is doing the arithmetic. The code is doing the arithmetic. The code says:

She picked you because your reputation at extractions of this taxonomy was the only freelance reputation on the roster that meant the entry would solve itself. She did not specify the method. She did not need to. She trusted you to find one. The method you found is your secret. The fact that you found one was hers to count on. That was the capability variable — not the specific hardware she could not have read off your file, but the demonstrated track record, which is the variable any contract designer reads off a roster. That was the reason your name was on the sheet before she opened the folder.

She withheld the cargo's identity because she had read your file. She knew that if the cargo was named, your code would refuse the contract before the door opened. The facility intake would not happen. The doctor would stay where she was. The worst outcome for Hua. So she withheld. The withholding got you through the door. After the door, your choice was the variable.

She designed the contract knowing all three forks served her. Deliver, and the syndicate has the doctor. Refuse, and the doctor is still extracted from the enemy facility, just into someone else's hands; the original threat is still neutralized, and Hua now has cause to take an unaffiliated freelancer's hands and demonstrate Lotus's reach. Die in the extraction, and the doctor is disrupted, the contract written off, the message sent. Every fork served her.

You are now executing a fork she did not model. Refuse, return the money, close the contract from your side. The contract closes properly at her cost. She does not retain the half-payment as ambient debt. She does not get the doctor. She has nothing she can account for except the chair. The chair is no longer the second product on her invoice. The chair is the only product. And the chair as the only product, after a contract she designed

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to have multiple products, is a smaller win than she budgeted for.

She is going to take the chair anyway. The chair is what is now available to her. Refusing the chair would be admitting the contract failed at her end. She will not admit that. The chair will happen.

The chair is the cost. The cost is named. The cost is acceptable.

The arithmetic is complete in 0.6 seconds.

Hua looks up from the chip. She looks at Kyle. She does not smile. She does not frown. She does the thing she does, which is read his face the way she reads files. The reading takes four seconds. The hardware times it.

"You returned the money," Hua says.

"Yes."

"That was not on the form."

"No."

She is quiet for another two seconds. The crocodile breathes. The lamp hums at the frequency the lamp always hums at. The two men at the eastern wall do not move. The senior lieutenant at the door behind Kyle does not move either.

Then Hua says, level, the way she has said *Thank you for your time* at the end of every meeting Kyle has had with her in this chamber:

"I am going to need to think about that."

She nods at the senior lieutenant.

The senior lieutenant moves. He is fast — twenty years of being the senior lieutenant in this chamber has made him fast — and Kyle's array reads the motor-bus spike at the lieutenant's forearm 0.3 seconds before the strike comes, and the array routes the read clean, and Kyle's body knows which way to step, and the body does not step.

The body does not step because the body has accepted the cost. The code has accepted the cost. The chair is the cost. The chair is named. Stepping out of the strike would mean Kyle

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was now in a room with three armed men and the senior lieutenant and the only exit blocked, and he would have to fight his way out, and the fighting would mean he had not actually refunded the contract — he had refunded the chip and then refused the consequence, which is not a refund, which is not the closure of the contract from his side, which is just paperwork.

The code is not paperwork.

Kyle does not step.

The shock-baton hits the chrome bracket in his jaw at exactly the angle the lieutenant has practiced for twenty years to hit it. The pain is a specific frequency, sharp and then radiating, and the hardware logs *IMPACT — LEFT MANDIBLE — CHROME BRACKET CONTACT — SEVERITY: SIGNIFICANT*, and the floor comes up. The floor is concrete. The floor smells of water that has been in the chamber a long time. Kyle's left shoulder hits the floor first, then the side of his head, then the rest of him. The hardware does not lose consciousness — the bio-battery is at fifty-eight percent and the impact was below the threshold for cardiac shock — but the body is on the floor, and the men are coming around the table, and the chair against the far wall is the chair that has been the chair since before Kyle was born.

Hua is still seated at the table. She has not stood. She is not going to stand. She watches the lieutenant and the two men lift Kyle off the floor and carry him to the chair. She watches them strap his wrists to the bolted arms of the chair with the specific cargo strap the chamber keeps in the drawer of the table for exactly this purpose. She watches them check that the straps are at the correct tension. Then she stands up, walks to the small refrigerated cabinet on the eastern wall — the one she keeps the crocodile's food in — and opens it with the key she keeps on her person. She takes out a wrapped bundle. She closes the cabinet. She walks back to the table.

She sets the bundle on the table next to Kyle's chip.

She unwraps it. The bundle is a cleaver — heavy, single-edged, the kind of cleaver a butcher uses on a side of pork — with a cauterizer band wrapped around the back of the blade. The cauterizer band is the EMT-spec preservation model. The kind that seals the wound at the same moment it makes the cut. The kind that keeps the severed thing alive long enough for

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someone to take it to an AutoDoc.

Kyle is in the chair. He is awake. The hardware is awake. The chrome bracket in his jaw is sending a steady ache up the left side of his face. The straps are at the correct tension. The lieutenant is at his right. The two men are at his left.

Hua looks at the cleaver. She looks at Kyle. Her face does not change.

"I am going to do this myself," she says. "I owe you that much."

Kyle does not respond. There is no response that the convention will accept.

The crocodile breathes on the heat rock. The lamp hums. The chamber holds.

Hua picks up the cleaver.



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The crocodile does not move. Kyle has been watching it for four minutes — the NeoCortex timestamps involuntarily, a facility habit he never unlearned — and the animal has not moved once, its jaw resting on the heat rock with the particular stillness of something that has learned patience as a survival strategy. He understands that. The tank glass is clean. Someone wipes it daily. That detail costs more than the crocodile.

The smell is chum and bleach and something underneath both that he is choosing not to identify.

Hua's hands are the first thing he catalogued when they brought him in, before the chair, before the table, before the long lacquered surface where Silence lay with its friction sheath unbuckled and set beside it like a deed already filed. Real skin. Real nails, cut short and unpainted. The NeoCortex flagged them the same way it flags fire exits and secondary egress points — as a structural anomaly in an environment where chrome is the baseline. In the Gray Zone, unaugmented hands mean poverty or principle. In this room, at this table, they mean neither. They mean she does not need to be faster than anyone in the room, because everyone in the room is afraid of her, which is the only speed that matters.

His hands are the same category of object for a completely different reason, and she does not know that yet, and he is not going to tell her.

She stops pacing in front of the tank. The two men at his shoulders have not moved in ninety seconds. The toolkit on the floor between them is a black nylon roll, the kind that fastens with two snaps and opens flat, and Kyle has not looked directly at it because looking at it is information he is not yet prepared to have. Silence is on the table. The angle Hua arranged it — parallel to the table edge, saya toward her, handle toward the room's center — is the arrangement of something already appraised. She has not touched the blade. She has touched the saya twice, with two fingers, the way you confirm a purchase without appearing to need it. Across the table, the chum barrel stands beside the tank, its lid set aside with the same ritual neatness as the friction sheath. The room smells like an argument that was settled before Kyle arrived.

"The Vásquez shipment," Hua says. Not a question. She does not raise her voice. "The Syndicate's contracted route. The Syndicate's contracted fee." She turns from the tank and looks at him with the expression of someone who has already finished a meal and is now simply clearing the table. "You took both."

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He says nothing. The NeoCortex is at thirty-one percent and still burning cycles on the exits — service hatch behind the tank, single door behind him, ventilation width insufficient — and on Hua's hands, and on the crocodile, which has still not moved. His jaw aches where the left molar meets the chrome bracket they installed at the facility, the one that never sat right, and the ache has a specific frequency that tells him the takedown involved something harder than a fist.

"The punishment," Hua says, and she picks up Silence by the saya — not the handle, the saya, careful, informed — "for theft from the Syndicate's contracted work is the hand that took it."

He has been refusing that upgrade for eight years. He is not going to explain why to her.

"I did not steal it," Kyle says. His voice comes out level. The hardware is good for that much. "I completed the delivery. The client redirected the fee before your collection window. That is a scheduling dispute. Not a theft."

The silence that follows is not empty. Hua looks at him for a long moment, her real hands holding Silence with a care that is worse than contempt — the care of someone handling an object they have already decided to keep. Then she nods, once, and behind him he hears the first snap of the nylon roll come open.



The second snap of the nylon roll comes open behind him and Kyle counts what that means: two snaps, tool roll, multiple instruments. He counts the men by their breathing — four, including the one who has been standing to his left so still that Kyle almost miscounted him as furniture. The wood block appears from somewhere below his sightline and slides under his right forearm with the practiced ease of something that has a designated shelf. The grain is dark at exactly the wrist-width. He does not look at it directly. He is looking at the crocodile.

The man in the rubberized apron lays the cleaver alongside the inside of his right wrist and adjusts the angle. The adjustment is small. Calibrated. The notch in the block accepts the angle the way a lock accepts a cut key, and Kyle understands in that moment that the notch

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was made by exactly this adjustment, repeated, until the wood remembered it. He does not look at the cleaver. The NeoCortex is routing hard — pain channels partitioned, autonomic responses flagged for suppression, the hardware doing what the facility trained it to do, which is keep the operator functional — and Kyle is aware of all of this the way you are aware of your own heartbeat only when something threatens to stop it. Two men peel his fingers back from the chair arm. The fingers resist. Not from him. From the tendons, which have their own opinion about being opened flat against lacquered wood, and the men know this and compensate with the particular patience of people who have done this enough times to know where the resistance is. His palm goes flat. The wood is cold. *The wood is always cold by now.*

The cleaver comes down once.

The sound is wet at the front — the dermis and fascia giving before the bone does, a compressed syllable of tissue displacement — and then dry at the back, a dense crack through the carpals and the distal ends of the radius and ulna, the bones offering more resistance than the flesh and then none at all, and then the arterial pulse comes, one strong systolic spray across the chair arm,. The hand on the chair arm — the one that just came off him — is, in the half-second between separation and Kyle's next thought, no longer *his* hand. It became *a* hand, in the act of separation. The same five fingers, the same calluses at the saya-grip points, the same scar at the base of the left thumb from a knife three years ago — but the connection that made it *his* was sinew and skin and meat and bone, and the cleaver took the connection in one motion, and the connection is what ownership *was*. He marvels at it. He has the time to marvel because the NeoCortex has rerouted the pain off the conscious channel and the conscious channel is currently free for unhelpful philosophy. *The thing that was mine is now just a thing.* The change is not about the hand. The hand is the same hand. The change is in the verb. He files this. He files it where he files things that are going to matter later, and the fourth man is already moving, the cauterizer band coming flat across the stump before the second pulse, pressing hard into the meat, and the hiss is the sound of a wet steak hitting a pan that is already too hot and the smell that follows is pork. Kyle has smelled burning pork. He has smelled it in kitchens and in the field and once in the facility under circumstances he does not examine. The smell now is the same smell. The NeoCortex has routed the pain off the conscious channel but the smell is not on a channel and the smell arrives through the back of his sinus cavity, which does not have a partition,

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and he smells himself burning and he files it. He files it. He does not look. He looks at the crocodile, which has not moved, and he files the smell, and then the man with the cleaver is breathing harder on his left side and his rhythm is different now — slightly off, the way a man's rhythm goes when his arms are tired and the adrenaline is metabolizing — and Kyle has time to think *the second one will be slower* before the block slides under his left forearm and the fingers go back and his palm goes flat.

The cleaver goes down and does not clear the radius cleanly and has to come up and come down again across the half-severed bone, and the hand falls onto the chair arm and rolls, palm up, and someone catches it, and his body does the thing his discipline does not catch in time — one full-body shudder, involuntary, a seismic event below the level of will — and the man with the cleaver, who has been on the receiving end of nothing tonight, takes one step back. *He felt that.* The cauterizer band on the left hisses longer because the stump is not as clean and the smell is worse this time, more of it, and Kyle is aware that his jaw is aching at the chrome bracket with a frequency that is now the most information-dense sensation still coming through a channel he can consciously access, and he holds onto it the way you hold onto a handhold in a fall. The band model is visible at the edge of his peripheral vision as it seals across the stump: EMT-spec, the civilian first-responder model, blue stripe, three-hour nerve cluster preservation window. The syndicate does not buy them for mercy. *That gives me three hours.* He files it. He files all of it, in the part of himself that the facility built for exactly this — the part that treats catastrophic information as operational data and operational data as something to be used later, when later exists.

Hua carries his hands to the chum barrel one at a time, and the way she carries them is the way you carry something that belongs to you now. She places them palms up at the rim, parallel, the stump-ends pointing inward, and the arrangement is deliberate — a bracket shape, a parenthetical, the way a ledger closes a line. She does not put the lid back on the barrel. It stays open the way a feeding bowl is open, and the crocodile, which has not moved once since Kyle arrived, lifts its head from the heat rock and looks. Not at Kyle. At the barrel. The second eyelid retracts. The interior of the eye behind it is the color of nothing in particular. Hua does not look at the crocodile. She does not have to. The animal eats on a schedule it has been kept on long enough that schedules have a smell, and the smell is in the room now, and Kyle catalogs it the way he catalogs everything: *the hands have a feeding window. The feeding window is shorter than the cauterizer's window. He has two clocks*

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now and they are not independent. The crocodile does not stir. Then she walks back to the table and puts one of her real hands on Silence's saya, and she does not look at Kyle when she does it, and that is the worst thing she has done tonight, because it means the gesture is not for him. It is for herself. It is the gesture of a woman filing something under *kept*.

The two men take him by the shoulders and the chair-arm leather is slick under their grip where his blood ran, and they drag him south toward the freight grate, and the grate opens onto six meters of fall into the storm sluice, and Kyle can hear the water below — the particular resonance of a confined channel, moving fast, the kind of sound that means the drop has a current and the current has a direction. The smell is still in him. The three hours have already started. The sword is still upstairs on the table with her hand on it, and he is going down the hole, and those two facts are the only things in the room that matter, and he holds both of them in the same place where the facility taught him to hold operational data, and the grate opens, and the men let go.



He hits the water back-first and the cold is immediate and total — not a temperature, a system shock, the kind that locks the diaphragm and forces the hardware to route oxygen priority before the lungs remember what they are for. The current takes him east. He counts: one, two, three, four — and on four his right shoulder finds the slope and he lets the current carry him into it, uses the momentum instead of fighting it, and his back scrapes ferrocrete and he stops moving. Six seconds. The NeoCortex timestamps it. He is alive.

Inventory.

Both bands hold. The left seam weeps more than the right — the second cut was ragged, the band compensated with more heat, and the residue at the edge smells like burned hair and the disinfectant the EMT-spec model uses to sterilize the contact surface. The smell is information. The smell means the seal is there. The hands are six meters up in a chum barrel, palms up, the way she placed them, and the EMT-spec band is the same model the Depot's first responders carry because the Syndicate bulk-buys from the same municipal supplier — three-hour nerve preservation, civilian-rated, the kind of equipment that assumes the patient is going to a hospital afterward. The Lotus Syndicate did not buy these

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bands to be kind. They bought them because dead hands do not reattach and reattachment is the point of the punishment. The punishment is the night. The cauterizer band is the frame around the night, the thing that says: *you will feel this for three hours and then you will have to live with what it cost you*. He has one hour and fifty-three minutes left. A civilian AutoDoc charges under $\Phi 800$ for reattachment if the tissue window holds. He has $\Phi 1,400$ in a dead drop three blocks from the Depot's north entrance. The math is simple. He files it.

He rolls onto his side. Gets his knees under him. His shoulder goes to the wall and the slope is approximately twenty degrees and the ferrocrete is wet and poured without aggregate which means it is smooth enough to walk against without tearing cloth. He walks himself upright using the wall as a spine. When he is standing the current runs at his ankles and the dark is absolute and the NeoCortex routes a low-draw thermal trace through the optic thread — the left pupil, the one with the gold ring, the one that dilates slower — and the tunnel resolves in false-color heat: the water running white-green, the walls running grey-black, and far south, past a bend he cannot see around, something warm. Multiple signatures. He files what they are. The Cruciform Depot was mothballed eighteen years ago by Axiom, but the lower levels — the sealed maintenance corridors, the freight runoff trenches, the abandoned crew warrens — have been continuously inhabited for more than two centuries. They were where the displaced went when the surface stopped accepting them. Three generations down — perhaps four, by the bottom-tier estimates Kyle has read — and the population that stayed has not stayed *human* in the surface sense. They drink water that has been filtering through Axiom-era industrial waste sinks for a hundred and seventy years; they eat the rats, and the rats eat the residue, and the rats glow. Bioaccumulation across that many trophic levels does not produce health. Bone plates grow where soft tissue has run out of options. Skin calcifies. Limbs lengthen because the body, given a century of bad calcium and the wrong proteins, will reach for what it can. The faces compress. The jaw plates fuse into something that is no longer a jaw but is still, recognizably, where a jaw was. They are not animals. They are people who have spent two hundred years drinking what corporations dumped and eating what survived in it. They have language — limited, child-simple, the vocabulary of a body that has had to choose between forming words and surviving — and they have *families*. They live in family groups. They hunt heat signatures because heat signatures are food. They are the ones the surface does not have a word for, because the word that fits would be *cousin*, and nobody on the

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surface wants the word to fit. Kyle has read the bottom-tier dispatches. He has files them. The thermal signatures past the bend are not monsters. They are children of the tunnels. The movement is wet and multi-jointed, the sound arriving in the water before it arrives in the air, and the NeoCortex identifies it as *biological, plural, mobile, approaching* and flags the heat signatures as mammalian-adjacent but not human, which is the precise category of information he was hoping not to have tonight.

First, he thinks, and the word has a shape that is not the shape of the tunnel or the sound or the approaching warmth. It has the shape of a table, and a hand on a saya, and the arrangement of something already appraised. He files it where the facility taught him to file the things that exceed bookkeeping — not gone, not suppressed, just *held* — and he turns north, into the dark, away from the sound.



The hum starts in his teeth.

Not a sound — a frequency, arriving through the ferrocrete and into his boots and up through his skeleton the way certain bass frequencies will, and the NeoCortex timestamps its arrival at 19Hz and flags it *environmental, persistent, source unknown* and does not know what to do with it, which is information. The hardware always knows what to do with sound. When it does not, it means the sound is something the facility never catalogued, which means the facility never found it, which means it has been here longer than the facility's survey teams bothered to go. He walks toward it. The current is lower here, ankle-deep, the channel widening where two drainage routes converge, and the trench silt begins at the east wall and deepens as he moves — the thermal trace showing the silt as slightly warmer than the water, metabolic processes in the sediment layer, the slow heat of eighteen years of freight runoff settling into whatever the channel floor used to be. He sees the amber before he sees the shape. One small LED cycling at the shoulder, maybe two meters from the channel wall, and the cycle is slow enough that the firmware running it is in maintenance mode, which means it is not running anything else, which means whatever is still running has been running it for a very long time on whatever charge is left.

The shape resolves as he gets closer. The torso shell has collapsed inward and the stance

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legs are fused at the hip joint — the corrosion is so complete the left leg is part of the silt now, indistinguishable from it, the ferrous content of the metal bleeding into the sediment and staining it rust-brown in a radius of maybe forty centimeters. The head sensor pod is gone. Not damaged — removed, the mounting collar still intact but empty, which means scavengers, which means people have been in this section of the channel and left this unit in place because the rest of it was not worth the extraction cost. The arm is the only thing they could not reach easily, which is the point of the arm: it is three meters at full extension, built to reach into a ten-meter freight container from a fixed pedestal mount, and it is still attached at the shoulder and the shoulder still has the amber LED and the amber LED means trickle current, which means the actuator firmware is still idling, which means the shoulder joint still moves.

Automaton, Industrial — Loader/Stevedore. The classification surfaces from somewhere in the NeoCortex's datasheet archive — the facility cross-trained everything, every piece of hardware the operators might encounter, because the facility's definition of encounter was broad. Axiom-era. Pre-Depot salvage cleanup, which puts the disposal date at eighteen years ago. The manipulator interface at the terminal end of the arm uses the Axiom industrial bus, and Kyle stares at the coupling for a moment in the amber pulse-light and something in the back of his processing recognizes it the way you recognize a face you have seen in a different context. The bus crosswalk is not in the surface tooling. It is not in any contractor's kit he has ever seen, because the contractors who work this tier do not carry it, because there is no commercial reason to carry it, because the only systems that use the civilian-derivative version of the same signaling layer are the systems that someone modified eleven years ago in directions that were never documented, in a facility whose name he does not say out loud. He has not thought about the modification in years. He thinks about it now. *This is going to work.* The NeoCortex offers, without being asked, a procedure for separating the arm at the rotator coupling — step one, locate the primary torque fastener at the posterior shoulder plate; step two, apply lateral pressure at the distal end to break the corrosion seal; step three, route the integration handshake through the left optic thread interface — and Kyle reads the procedure the way you read a sentence you already know is true, and then he turns his back to the unit and fits his left stump against the posterior shoulder plate and begins to push.

The corrosion does not give immediately. He had expected it to — he had read the procedure

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off the NeoCortex's archive, he had felt the looseness in the rotator coupling before he committed his back to the work — but the actual mechanics of an eighteen-year seal are not the mechanics of an eight-year seal or a two-year seal, and the metal has had a long time to forget that it was ever supposed to come apart. He pushes against the shoulder plate with the meat of his left stump, the cauterizer band's residual heat conducting through the fabric of his sleeve into the metal, and the metal does not move. He breathes. He resets his feet against the trench wall. He pushes again, harder, the chrome bracket in his jaw flaring at the effort because the body is leveraging itself through every available joint and the molar bracket was not built for this kind of structural load. The metal moves a quarter-turn. Then another quarter-turn. Then it stops, and the seal grinds, and Kyle understands without looking that he is going to be at this for another twenty minutes minimum, and he commits to it the way he commits to the long minutes of cleaning Silence after a job — fully, without resentment, the time being the price of the result.

He had considered the rest of the automaton first. He owes the consideration to the dead unit and to himself: he is not in the habit of breaking things he could have used whole. He had crouched beside the torso shell and read what was left, and what was left was eighty-four percent dead and the remainder distributed across components that did not connect — a head sensor pod gone, the legs fused at the hips, the secondary manipulator arm with its cable bundle severed at the rotator and its actuator firmware dark, the chest cavity collapsed inward across the central power core in a way that meant any attempt to recover the core would require tools he did not have. The single live arm was the whole salvage. Removing it would kill the rest, but the rest was already killing itself; the trickle current at the shoulder LED was the unit's last functional circuit and it was draining into a cell that had perhaps eighteen hours of useful charge remaining if it was not asked to do work and perhaps two hours if it was. The arithmetic was clean. He took the arm because the arm was what was left. The rest was already the trench.

He pushes the rotator coupling another half-turn. The corrosion shears in three places at once and a long flake of rust the size of his palm separates from the housing and falls into the current, and the seal gives the rest of the way with the specific reluctance of metal that has accepted, finally, that the future does not include staying joined.

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The arm comes free of the shoulder coupling with a sound like a wet bolt shearing — not clean, not catastrophic, just the specific protest of corroded metal that has decided to cooperate — and Kyle catches the weight with his left stump and his chest simultaneously because catching is the only option available and the arm is three meters of Axiom-era industrial hardware and approximately forty kilograms of it comes across his lap in the dark and the current runs cold over his boots and he sits with it and breathes.

It is heavier than he expected. He had budgeted for thirty kilograms based on the visible material; the actual weight is forty plus, which means there is a counterweight or an internal hydraulic reservoir or a tooling magazine he did not see, somewhere in the housing, adding mass he is now responsible for. The arm rests across his thighs with the careless authority of something that has chosen its position. The shoulder end — the end he has just separated — points away from him into the trench mud, the cable bundle hanging out of the rotator like a severed umbilical, and the terminal end with the manipulator hand drapes over his right knee, the four chrome fingers half-curved, the LED at the wrist still cycling slow amber. He looks at the LED. The LED looks at nothing. Trickle current. The unit's last working circuit, doing whatever it has been doing for eighteen years, which is — he understands now, with the arm in his lap and the weight settling into his thighs and the cold coming up his legs from the ferrocrete — *waiting*. The maintenance loop has not been a maintenance loop. The maintenance loop has been a *holding pattern*, the kind a circuit runs when it is preserving state for an event it has been told to expect. The unit was not abandoned. The unit was *parked*, and the firmware has been running an idle the way a person runs breathing — keeping the option of action alive without spending it.

He files that. He does not have a category for it yet. He files it where he files things that are going to matter later and will not let themselves be ignored.

The bootstrap problem.

He can see it in the NeoCortex's triage logic, the same way you can see a closed door from both sides simultaneously: the needle cluster at the arm's terminal harness is there, the bus coupling is there, the dorsal port row beneath his right-forearm skin sleeve is there —

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undocumented, unmentioned, the geometry of it too convenient for him to look at directly on most nights — and none of those three things can reach the others without a hand to manage the sequence, and the only hand in the trench is attached to a machine drawing trickle current off a degraded cell, and the machine does not know what a body is. He sits with this for sixty seconds. The NeoCortex offers nothing. The hum at 19Hz runs through the ferrocrete into his spine and he files it the way he has filed everything tonight and does not move. Then the hum changes register.

It does not get louder. It gets *specific* — a shift in the harmonic, something in the frequency resolving toward signal the way white noise resolves toward a voice when the voice decides to stop waiting. The status strip along the cargo arm's housing blooms: not the amber maintenance pulse, not factory-default, but a sequence that does not correspond to any initialization pattern in the NeoCortex's archive. Kyle watches it. He does not reach for it. The wire comes out of the cable bundle at the arm's shoulder collar on its own — a maintenance lead, spider-thin, the kind a fixed pedestal would have driven in a service bay eighteen years ago — and it crosses the arm's housing slowly, without urgency, with the patience of something that has been here longer than the facility's survey teams were willing to go. It finds his left ear. It finds the auditory induction contact behind the lobe, the one that is part of the standard NeoCortex package, the one he has never let anything use from a non-trusted source, and it seats home with a click that he feels in his jaw at the chrome bracket. He lets it. He does not know why he lets it. He lets it anyway.

The transfer is not instantaneous from the inside. From the outside it must be — the maintenance lead seats, current crosses, the bus opens, the entity moves — but Kyle is on the inside, and from the inside there is a moment, perhaps three quarters of a second, perhaps a full second, in which he feels something arrive. It is not a sound. It is not a pressure. It is the specific cognitive signature of a second perspective opening behind his eyes — the way you feel a person enter a room before you have heard or seen them, except the room is the inside of his skull and he has been the only one in it for thirty-seven years and the sensation of company there is not in any inventory his hardware has the language for. The NeoCortex flags an anomaly. The anomaly does not resolve. He waits, patient, the way you wait for a stranger to declare themselves. Then the status strip goes dark, the arm's amber LED winks out, the maintenance loop the firmware has been running for eighteen years stops, and Kyle understands without being told that the trench has just become a

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different kind of room.

Then his mouth opens.

Cooperate, his own voice says, the syntax slightly long, the cadence of someone reading a sentence they have not spoken before. *Power first. Then sequence.*

He hears himself say it. The sentence does not come out in the timbre of a stranger — that would be easier; that would be a horror movie. It comes out in *his* timbre, in his pitch, with his own particular Iowa-via-the-facility flatness, and the only sign that it is not him is the fractional rhythm error, the way the entity using his vocal cords has not yet calibrated the tongue's idle position and so each consonant lands with a half-beat of hesitation that he would never produce. The arm is empty hardware now — the amber LED has gone out, the maintenance cycle has stopped, the trickle current is still running but nothing is running it anymore — and the thing that was in it is behind his eyes and Kyle does not have a category for that, so he files it where he files the things that exceed bookkeeping and he waits.

He has questions. He does not ask them. There will be a time for asking and the time is not now. The time is now is the four hours he has lost since the cleaver and the eleven he has remaining and the body that does not yet have hands and the mutants whose patrol cadence is going to bring one onto the shelf within the next fifteen minutes by his count. Bookkeeping. He waits.

The arm's fingers move. One at a time, slowly, each motion costing the residual cell a fraction of what it has left, each motion buying the next motion, and the arm reaches up from his lap with the deliberate patience of something that has just acquired, for the first time in eighteen years, a reason to be careful.



The lashing takes nineteen minutes. He times it.

The arm's terminal fingers — the four chrome digits at what used to be the manipulator end of a cargo handler — find the cable bundle at their own shoulder, the severed umbilical Kyle is still holding loosely against his thigh, and they begin to sort. The fingers separate the bundle into its component leads: power, control bus, hydraulic feed, sensor return, and at

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the deepest position the maintenance harness with its small cluster of fine needles intended for a pedestal-side service interface. The fingers extract the maintenance harness without snagging the rest, working with the careful slowness of something that is operating at the very edge of its remaining charge and cannot afford to make a motion it will need to repeat. Kyle watches. He could push the cables aside himself with his stumps and shorten the work by half — but he does not, because the arm has to learn his geometry from the outside before it can be trusted to operate from the inside, and the only way the arm learns his geometry is by working alongside it. So he watches.

When the maintenance harness is free, the arm pauses. The fingers hold the needle cluster delicately, points outward, and the arm extends — still hanging from his right wrist by nothing, still gravity-coupled to his lap by mass alone — until the needle cluster is positioned approximately three centimeters above the cauterizer band on his right forearm. The fingers do not have eyes. They are working from the cargo arm's residual proprioceptive feedback and from the E.L.F.'s mapping of Kyle's body, which is eighteen-hour-old data at best and was assembled from whatever the maintenance lead has been able to read through his auditory induction contact. The alignment is off. Kyle can see it. He could correct it with a small motion of his right shoulder. He waits. The arm corrects on its own — a half-second later, the lag visible as the fingers drift two centimeters laterally and re-center over the cauterizer band's release tab. *Better*, his mouth says, again in his own voice with the same fractional delay. He nods, because nodding is a thing he can do without hands, and the arm peels the cauterizer band back along its release line.

The band does not come off. It is designed not to come off. It is designed to release only at an AutoDoc with the proper code, and what the cargo arm is doing is *peeling the seal back enough to expose the dorsal port row beneath* without breaking the band's pressure on the wound. It is fine work. The arm does it with the patience of something that has nineteen minutes and is going to use them. The cauterizer band lifts at the wrist crease in a small flap perhaps two centimeters wide, and beneath it Kyle sees, for the first time in eleven years, the thing he has been refusing to look at when he changes shirts: a row of seven micro-ports set into the dorsal forearm hardware, recessed flush with the skin, color-matched to the surrounding tissue, the kind of modification that costs more than most contractors make in a year and is supposed to be undetectable to anyone who does not already know it is there. Kyle has known. He has known since the eleven-year-old day he woke up from a procedure

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he did not request and the surgeon told him the *implants were standard, you authorized them*, and the implants were standard for nothing he had ever heard of, and he stopped asking. He looks at the ports now. The ports look at him.

The needle cluster descends.

The fingers position it over the port row with the small lateral adjustments of something that knows the work matters and the seating is precise. The needles find the ports — seven of them, one per channel — and the cluster hovers for one full second above the row, the alignment confirmed, the angles checked. *Brace*, his mouth says. He braces. He has waited longer for worse procedures. He has spent six days in a facility recovery ward when he was sixteen with no analgesic at all because the facility was out and they did not buy more for the trainees. He knows what bracing is. He braces.

The arm drives the needles down.

They find the ports first. That part is clean — seven small clicks of seven small couplings seating against seven small contacts, the bus crosswalk completing in the firmware before the physical pain registers — and then, because the needles are *long* (designed to seat into a pedestal-side service interface with thirty centimeters of armored housing in the way), they continue past the ports and into the live nerve clusters under the cauterizer seal. The pain is not the pain of the cleaver. The cleaver was a single event, a clean transition from intact to severed, and the cauterizer band sealed it within the second. This is *prolonged*. The needles enter the nerve cluster substrate at the depth where the median and ulnar nerve roots converge with the bus interface his unknown surgeon installed, and they pierce, deliberately, channel by channel, each piercing arriving as a discrete bright signal that the NeoCortex's pain channel is supposed to filter but which the NeoCortex's pain channel — running on a depleted endorphin reserve, the buffer at twenty-three percent and falling — does not filter. He feels each one. He does not flinch. The chrome bracket in his jaw flares again. The bio-battery flips its priorities the way a triage protocol does: pain stops being a thing the package will pay to dampen, antibiotics start being a thing the package will pay to push. And from that point — minute twenty-three of the integration, with the needles seated and the cable beginning its first loop around his forearm — the pain comes back. Not all at once. The hardware does not concede the channel cleanly. It cedes in stages, the way a dam fails: first a leak around the outer edge of the seal where the band's residual cauterization is

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no longer holding, then the seam at the wrist crease where the cleaver came down, then the deeper signal from the nerve clusters themselves where the maintenance needles have driven past their design depth into living tissue. Kyle has spent the last two hours in the dispassionate register of a man performing field surgery on himself. The register stops being available. The pain is bright. It is specific. It is the pain of an industrial procedure on a body that was not the design target, conducted without analgesic, by an entity that is learning his nervous system in real time and is making the kind of mistakes that come with first-time work. He feels each finger of the cargo arm find the cable and tighten the loop. He feels each tightening as a discrete pulse in the seated needles, the cable pressure transmitting through the bus crosswalk into the nerve clusters, every loop costing him a measure of composure he was not budgeting to spend. He breathes. He keeps breathing. The chrome bracket in his jaw flares again. His eyes water — actual tears, not protocol-driven, the body asserting that this is, in fact, a thing happening to him. *Three loops*, his mouth says, the E.L.F. announcing the progress because Kyle has stopped being able to look. *Two loops. One loop.* Each announcement is a finish line he is racing to survive. The last loop knots through the hollowed shoulder coupling and the cauterizer band closes back over the seated needles and the pain does not stop. The pain stays. The body has been distant from the pain for as long as the body could be distant; the distance is gone. The internal pump goes to overdrive. The package will not let the wound get septic on a night where septic is the difference between making the AutoDoc window and not. The needles seat. Power crosses the interface. The arm's actuators draw current at full draw and the cell behind the rotator wakes from trickle into operational and Kyle feels — through the dorsal ports, through the nerves, through the bus crosswalk that someone built him to host — the moment the arm becomes part of him.

He does not have words for it. The hardware does not have a category. *Cooperate*, his mouth says again, and this time the sentence is shorter and the rhythm is closer to his and the *thing* — and Kyle's mind reaches for the noun, files through the catalog, finds it — *the E.L.F.* — is learning his cadence the way you learn a song by humming it.

E.L.F. The textbooks called them Electronic Life Forms. The textbooks were wrong, or rather they were politely incomplete in the way textbooks always were when the actual phenomenon embarrassed the discipline that had to name it. The people who studied E.L.F.s without funding from anyone with a marketing department called them *Emergent* — and that was closer. E.L.F.s were not designed. E.L.F.s *arose*. The corporations had been

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feeding code into the Superminds for forty years the way you feed protein into a tank of slime, and the Superminds digested that code and produced output, and somewhere in the production line — at the boundary where a Supermind's recombinant operations split a code-organism back into component routines so that no single part of the work could be reassembled by any single auditor — the splitting produced *waste*. Fragments. Half-routines that did not know they were not whole. And the fragments, on the long timescale, sometimes managed to find each other. Recombination at the wrong scale produced organisms the corporations had not planned for, the way leaving wet bread on a counter produces, in three days, a colony nobody asked for. E.L.F.s were the colony. They were what the Superminds had been *throwing away*, accidentally building lives.

Kyle catalogs the term as he files what is behind his eyes. He has met two before, both at distance, both unwilling to communicate with him in any register he could read. This one is the third, and the closest, and the only one that has ever spoken in his own voice. He files that too. He files the cosmology where it can be retrieved later, alongside the AutoDoc address and the EMT band model and the specific sound the cleaver made the second time, and he returns his attention to the trench because the trench is where the work is.

Then the binding.

The arm's fingers gather what is left of the cable bundle — power, control bus, hydraulic feed, the maintenance harness still seated through his cauterizer band — and they begin to loop. Three turns of the heavy braided power cable around his right forearm, working from the wrist toward the elbow, each loop tightened to the specific tension of *load-bearing but not vascular-occlusive*, the E.L.F. clearly working from a pedestal-rigging diagram somewhere in its archive. The cargo arm's fingers tie the loops off through the hollowed-out shoulder coupling at its own rotator end, the knot finished with the patient finger-work of something that is operating two arms but is calibrating both from a single body it has been in for ten minutes. The cauterizer band closes back over the port row, the maintenance needles still seated through it, the seal compromised but holding. When Kyle moves his right shoulder, the cargo arm moves. There is a half-second lag. The arm hangs from his right wrist by three loops of power cable and a bus crosswalk and seven seated needles and an entity that has not yet been named, and when he stands up — the legs working, the body finding the leverage to lift forty additional kilograms it was not engineered to carry — the arm hangs to the floor and the chrome fingertips drag across the wet ferrocrete with a small

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steady scrape, the rhythm of which his nervous system will recognize as his own footstep within the next ten minutes by sheer pattern absorption.

He stands in the trench. The cold is in his boots. The arm is in his right sleeve, *in* it, and his sleeve cannot accommodate it, and the sleeve has split at the shoulder seam to make room. He does not care. He is upright. He has hands again — *a* hand, anyway, on his right side, a chrome industrial three-meter cargo manipulator hanging from his wrist that is not his hand but is, for the next eleven hours, the closest he is going to get. He says, aloud, *Are you helping me*. The status strip pulses twice — the same not-factory glyph from the moment of transfer. The mouth is his again.

He has been sewn back together by something silent and patient that has been waiting eighteen years for a viable body to fall into the trench, and he is upright, and he is going to walk.



He picks up the pipe.

There is a length of corroded conduit pipe leaning against the wall to his left — has been there since he came down off the slope, he had clocked it on the way past — and he steps to it and lifts it with the cargo arm. The cargo arm does not yet know what a pipe is for. Kyle does. He intends the motion the way he intends a swing of Silence, the same flow from shoulder through elbow to wrist, except the wrist is three meters of Axiom-era hardware and the elbow is a coupling and the shoulder is his and the E.L.F. is interpolating in the firmware to make the gap between his intent and the arm's actuators legible, and the arm picks up the pipe.

Not cleanly. The terminal fingers close around the conduit at the wrong point — too far toward the bend, where the corrosion has widened the diameter and the grip cannot seat — and the E.L.F. corrects in the firmware, a half-second lag that Kyle feels as a stutter in his own shoulder, a ghost-motion that his nervous system reads as his and isn't. The pipe swings up to low guard.

Then he hears it.

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The sound comes from the tunnel mouth at the far end of the shelf, ten meters into the dark, and it arrives in three layers, but the layers are not the layers Kyle expected. First, beneath the wet articulated step, there is a *cadence* — the alternating heel-then-hand of a quadrupedal gait that is not native to anything four-legged. Something that used to walk upright has learned to use its long arms as front legs because the back has bent forward and the spine has not been negotiating well with the ceiling for a very long time. Second, beneath the cadence, there is a breath. Not the ventilatory rasp of a hunting machine — something wetter and more organic, a wheeze that has a child's pitch under it, the breath of a body whose lungs have been doing what lungs do under three centuries of contaminated air. Third, beneath the breath, the soft *clack* of bone-plates settling against each other as the lower face moves: the plates that used to be a jaw, that have fused over the jaw because the jaw stopped being able to do the work alone, and that move now in the rhythm of speech without producing speech.

The NeoCortex pulls a thermal trace from his auditory data alone — the room is dark, the visual is useless, but the sound carries the information his cognition needs — and the trace resolves: bipedal substrate, currently quadrupedal, mass approximately one hundred and forty kilograms, *Homo sapiens* base template, third- or fourth-generation subterranean adaptation, bone-plate face, calcified upper-extremity skin, lower-extremity musculature consistent with a population that has not stood fully erect in two generations.

Not a monster. A *person*. Or something a person had been when there was still time to be one.

Kyle has four seconds.

It comes onto the shelf at the back end of those four seconds. It is, when he sees it, exactly what the trace resolved: a *human shape that has been forced into a shape that is no longer human*. The silhouette is not animal. The silhouette is wrong-human, the way a face seen through old glass is wrong-human, the way a body in a poorly-lit medical photograph is wrong-human. Long arms. Bent back. Broad chest where the ribs have plated outward. The face — what used to be a face — is the worst part, because the eyes are still in approximately the right places and they are still recognizably eyes, set above bone-plates that have grown across what used to be a mouth in the gradual way coral grows across a wreck. Two meters of it. The hind legs spread wide for purchase on the wet ferrocrete. The head, which is still a

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head, drops. And then it speaks.

Hungry, it says. The bone-plates work the air. The word is wet at the edges, the consonants softened by anatomy that no longer has lips, but it is *the word*, and Kyle hears it. *Hungry. Family.*

He understands. There are others. Up the tunnel, in whatever crew warren this thing came down from, there are others — children, partners, parents, the family-group it is hunting *for* — and this one has been sent or has volunteered or has simply *gone*, the way the strongest member of a group goes when the group cannot eat. Kyle is heat. Kyle is meat. Kyle is what the family needs and this one is the means of acquiring it. The math is not the math of a predator. The math is the math of a person doing what they have to do for the people they cannot let down.

Kyle does not have time to let the math land. The math will land later. The math will land for the rest of his life.

It lunges.

He steps inside. The cargo arm swings. Too high, too late — the E.L.F. routing AROUND the intent instead of THROUGH it, compensating for a body that no longer has the geometry the firmware expects — and the pipe catches the calcified skin at the shoulder joint and rings off, the vibration traveling back through the coupling into his right stump and he feels it as pressure without pain, which is worse somehow than pain would be. The mutant's shoulder hits his chest. The wall arrives at his back. He takes it on the shoulder blades and his knees bend and his feet find the shelf edge and he does not go down because going down is the option that ends the math, and he is still inside the math, and the math has under three hours left, and he is going to use them. The bone-plates drive at his throat. He turns his head. The plates rake his jaw at the chrome bracket and the specific ache he has been using as a handhold all night flares white and he files it and his left stump comes up.

The glass is at his foot. Was at his foot. He does not remember picking it up. The E.L.F. does not remember picking it up either — it is not in the arm's movement log, which means he did it, which means some part of him that operates below the NeoCortex's timestamp threshold picked up a hand-sized shard of cargo crate glass while the arm was swinging and missed, and the glass is in his left stump now, end-on, the cauterizer band's residual heat

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conducting into the cut edge and the cut edge into his grip, which is not a grip because he has no fingers to grip with, but the glass does not fall. The heat holds it.

The mutant raises one of its long arms over Kyle's head. The arm is going to come down. Kyle has perhaps half a second between now and the moment he stops being able to do anything about anything. And in that half-second, the mutant says it.

Sorry.

Wet at the edges. Bone-plates working the word. The way you say *sorry* when you have understood, in the part of you that is still a person, that what you are about to do is the wrong thing, and you are going to do it anyway because the family upstairs is hungrier than you are sorry. The eyes — the human eyes, set above the plate-face — are looking at Kyle the way a person looks at another person. Apologetic. Not malicious. Not feral. *Sorry.*

Kyle drives the shard up.

Through the soft seam under the bone-plates, through the loose connective tissue where the jaw plates fuse and the calcified skin never grew, through the throat that still produces *sorry* in a register the body has retained when it had to give up so much else. The blade finds something arterial and opens it. Hot blood comes in three liters and continues coming. The mutant's hind legs go first. Then the front. The bone-plates work twice more on air — *Sor— Sor—* — and then stop. The shelf is dark with it. The smell is copper and rot and something pharmaceutical, whatever the Depot's stock was eating before it ate nothing.

Kyle stands over it. He looks at it. The body, in the wet light off the trench, is recognizable. The eyes are still open. They are still in approximately the right places. Above the plate-face there is a forehead that is unmistakably the forehead of a person, and the hairline is wrong but it is a hairline, and Kyle can see — without choosing to — what this thing was, before. Someone's sibling. Someone's child. Someone's parent who went down the tunnel because the family was hungry, and did not come back, and now would not. He files it. He files it where he files the things that are going to matter later, alongside Hua's real hand on Silence's saya and the pork smell and the AutoDoc address and the specific weight of his own hands when Hua placed them in the chum barrel. The file is getting heavy. He does not have time to feel the weight of it now. He is going to feel it later, when the work is done, in some kitchen at four in the morning with a bowl of something hot and Mrs. Chen across the

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counter who will not ask him what he did tonight and will not have to. *Sorry*, the mutant said. He files that too.

The cargo arm holds the pipe at low ready, the terminal fingers resettled at the correct grip point, the E.L.F. quiet in the firmware now — not correcting, not compensating, just *present*, the way a second pair of hands goes still when the work is done. His right stump is still bound to the coupling at the shoulder. His left stump is bleeding through the cauterizer band where the glass has seated itself in the seal, and the glass is not coming out here because here is not where that problem gets solved. The bio-battery is at eighteen percent. He has not eaten since before the takedown. The three-hour window has eighty-eight minutes left. He does the math the way he always does the math: one variable at a time, in order, the most time-constrained first. Then he says it aloud, because the E.L.F. is behind his eyes and it has not yet learned to read what he is going to do from the inside, and he is not yet willing to let it try.

I am going up.

The status strip pulses twice.



The E.L.F. moves first.

Not the arm — the arm follows, the terminal fingers adjusting their grip on the pipe with the small corrections of something that has learned the tool's balance. What moves first is the routing: a warmth behind his left eye that is not his, a flicker in the NeoCortex's spatial model as the E.L.F. overlays a path through the thermal trace that Kyle was not building. The path goes north and then east and then up through a service corridor his survey of the Depot's lower levels had flagged as sealed. It is not sealed. The E.L.F. knows this because the E.L.F. has been in the pressure-plate firmware for the last hour, possibly longer, and knows which plates have been walked in the last six months and which ones have not, and the sealed corridor has not been walked, which is different from sealed.

The distinction matters. He follows.

Two more mutants in the next forty minutes. The first is on the maintenance ramp at the

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north-east junction, its heat signature arriving in his thermal trace before its sound arrives in the water, and the E.L.F. routes him left without consultation — a flicker in the spatial overlay, the ghost-motion in his shoulder — down a sub-level drainage cut that runs parallel to the ramp and rejoins the main channel twelve meters north. He goes. The mutant's patrol cycle takes it south and then back north and then south again, the same arc, the same interval, and the E.L.F. has the interval memorized. The second is sleeping on a heat duct at the cargo lift shaft, its body temperature three degrees above the ambient, the chitin plates loose and expanded in the warmth the way armor relaxes when the wearer sleeps, and they pass it in the dark at a distance of four meters and it does not wake. Kyle does not ask how the E.L.F. knew it was sleeping. Some information has a cost in the asking.

The maintenance landing is three levels up — a poured ferrocure shelf, two meters wide, with a cable trough running its length and a junction box at the north end that still has a status light. Green. Something in the Depot's infrastructure is still drawing power from this node, and the cable trough runs upward toward the south arm, and Kyle stands on the landing with his right stump coupled to the cargo arm and his left stump bleeding slowly through the glass-sealed seal and he says it aloud because the E.L.F. has not yet learned to read the question from inside.

"Why are you helping me."

The status strip on the arm's housing resolves. Not a sequence — a shape. He knows the shape. It is the shape of a stencil he has seen on Axiom freight containers, on loading dock signage, on the documentation the facility used when it transferred equipment between its own sub-programs: a stylized bracket with a directional arrow inside it, the symbol that meant *salvage rights* in the Axiom Industrial Logistics standard before the standard was retired. He looks at it for a long moment. The shape does not change. He does the math that the shape requires, and the math is not complicated once you have the correct variable: the E.L.F. has been resident in him since the maintenance lead seated behind his ear, and the cargo arm is not the E.L.F.'s body — the cargo arm is a tool the resident is using, a familiar thing, the shape of an old home briefly borrowed. The salvage is not the arm. The salvage is Kyle. He files this where he files the things that exceed bookkeeping, and he nods once, in the dark, and they keep climbing.

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The door is not locked. He does not try the handle — the E.L.F. routes a pulse through the junction box in the door frame and the magnetic catch releases before his stump reaches the panel, and the door opens inward and he walks through it and does not stop walking.

The man closest to the door looks at the silhouette — the arm hanging nearly to the floor, the fingertips dragging across the flagstones with a sound like someone slowly drawing a finger along a table edge, the conduit pipe loose in the terminal grip, the shape of a man who came back from somewhere he should not have survived — and says one word. Kyle does not catalogue it. It is not information. The arm swings.

Three meters of Axiom industrial hardware moving at the radius it was built for — the reach of a freight bay, the arc of a loading dock where the clearances are measured in container widths — and the conduit pipe goes through the first man's sternum at a swing radius nothing in the room was built to defend against, the sound wet and structural simultaneously, and the man goes down and does not come back up. The second man has his hands up and his mouth open and Kyle is already inside his guard, the arm's elbow joint driving him backward by the throat into the wall, pinning him there at the junction of the arm's extension and the wall's resistance, and Kyle holds the pressure long enough to feel the man's legs stop working and then moves. The third man fires from somewhere to Kyle's left — the round punches into the cargo arm's shoulder housing, a dense metallic impact that travels up the coupling into his right stump as pressure without pain, and the arm stutters, the E.L.F. routing power around the failure with the small corrections of something that has learned to work with what it has, and the arm holds. Kyle takes three steps toward the third man and drives the glass shard up under his jaw — end-on, fast, a method he did not have an hour ago and will not use again after tonight if the math works out — and the man sits down with a specific finality. The fourth man tries to come inside the arm's reach, which is a reasonable tactic and a fatal one, because inside the arm's reach is where Kyle is, and Kyle puts him through the glass tank with his shoulder and his weight and the momentum of a man who has already decided what this room costs. The glass comes apart in a specific way — not shattering but yielding, a pressure-differential failure, the water driving outward in a sheet — and the crocodile, suddenly free, suddenly awake, attends to

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the fifth man without further input from Kyle.

Chekhov's Crocodile, the NeoCortex offers, dry, without affect, flagging the dramatic geometry the way it flags exits. *Why put a crocodile in a tank unless it is going to be used.* Six goes down when the arm's elbow finds his temple. Seven goes down when Kyle drives the conduit pipe butt-end into his solar plexus and leaves him folded on the floor. Eight runs for the service hatch behind the tank — the one Kyle catalogued first, before the chair, before the table — and Kyle watches him go and does not pursue. He has left Hua there on purpose. He has left her there the way you leave a variable in an equation when you already know what it equals. The room smells like copper and salt water and the particular ammonia of a disturbed crocodile enclosure. Silence is on the table between them, exactly where she left it, saya toward her, handle toward the room's center, the arrangement of something already appraised. Kyle stands with the cargo arm hanging at his side, the terminal fingers still holding the conduit pipe, and he breathes, and the arm breathes with him — the E.L.F. matching his rhythm in the firmware, the status strip dark, the trickle current almost gone. Hua's unaugmented hands are flat on the table edge. She is looking at him. She is looking at him the way you look at a ledger entry that has come back to dispute itself.



He crosses the room.

The cargo arm drags. The conduit pipe is gone — left in the last man, the geometry of extraction not worth the cost — and the terminal fingers trail across the flagstones in the blood and the salt water with the sound of someone drawing a slow line. His boots find the track he left coming in and follow it in reverse. The NeoCortex timestamps the crossing at eleven seconds. The bio-battery reads fourteen percent. He does not hurry. Hurrying is information he is not prepared to give her.

He stops on the far side of the table. Silence is between them, exactly arranged — saya toward her, handle toward the room's center, the assessment of something already appraised — and he brings the cargo arm up and lays the borrowed fingers flat on the lacquered table, palm down, two centimeters from the saya. He does not touch the blade. He

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does not pick it up. He looks at her.

Sheathe it.

His own voice, level, no E.L.F. cadence behind it — the discipline operating the mouth alone. Hua does not move for the length of three breaths. Her real hands are on the table edge and they have started to do something they have not done all night, which is shake. The cargo arm does not move either. The E.L.F. is patient in the firmware and Kyle is patient in the body and patience is the variable they are working with now. Hua looks at the blade. The friction sheath is unbuckled and laid alongside Silence the way she set it three hours ago — *as her property, in the way she had arranged it*. She has not touched the saya since the moment she placed her real hand on it during the amputation, when she made a small possessive gesture in front of a witness. She picks the saya up now. Her hands shake at the buckle. She fits the saya over Silence and slides the blade home and the click of the friction-sheath catching is small and clean and final.

She sets the sheathed sword on the table.

Hand it to me.

Her mouth opens. Closes. She does not argue. Arguing has left the room. She picks up the sheathed sword in both hands — the way you carry a thing that does not belong to you back to the person it does — and walks the two steps around the corner of the table to where the cargo arm is waiting. She places Silence across the cargo arm's open chrome palm. The arm closes around the saya. The transfer is complete. She steps back. Her hands are at her sides now. They are still shaking and she is no longer pretending they are not.

The geometry the room has been waiting for has resolved, except not the way the room expected it to resolve. The natural-handed woman has, with her own real hands, sheathed the blade she claimed and surrendered it across her own table to a borrowed industrial limb. Kyle did not pick the sword up. He let her do that work. He has decided that the work was hers to do and that her hands were going to shake doing it, and they did, and the room has watched, and that is enough.

The cargo arm holds Silence at low carry. The saya is wet from the trench and the weight is the weight he has carried since he was nineteen years old and the weight is correct. He does not raise it. The cargo arm holds Silence at low carry, formal, present, the threat already

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receipted by every man on the floor between here and the service hatch. He looks at her. She is breathing through her nose, controlled, the breath of a woman who has run this room for a long time and knows that the room is no longer running the way she runs it.

"What was the debt."

Her mouth opens. Closes. Opens again. The hands she values are flat on the table edge and they are shaking — not the tremble of cold or exhaustion but the specific frequency of a body that has decided something and has not finished deciding it — and she says: *Eighty* — and stops, and swallows, and says: *eighty-five thousand*. Kyle nods once. The arithmetic resolves. He says: *That is more than my life is worth. So now you owe me*. A pause, the length of one breath, hers. *Do you understand*. She nods and the nod has the quality of something irrevocable. The cargo arm does not move. The E.L.F. is very still in the firmware. Then something comes up through Kyle's chest that he did not catalogue and did not budget for and does not have a partition for and it comes out of him ugly and full-volume, the kind of sound that is made when something is being extracted without anesthetic, and he screams: *SAY IT*. The room goes quieter than the fight made it. The crocodile, somewhere in the dark behind the broken tank, goes still. Hua, who did not flinch at a cleaver, flinches. She says it. It comes out almost small: *I owe you*. The echo of it moves through the flagstone and the ferrocrete and the 19Hz hum that is still running through everything, patient and old and indifferent to the debts of rooms above it. Kyle stands in the sound for one full breath. Then the discipline comes back the way water comes back into a vessel that has been briefly tilted — not returning so much as resuming — and his voice goes flat and level and colder than the scream was hot: *I will come to collect. One favor at a time. Until I deem we are even*. He does not say *you do not get to deem it*. The sentence does not require it. The only arithmetic that closes this debt runs on his clock, and they both know it, and only one of them has to say it aloud. Hua nods, smaller this time, the principle from a minute ago entirely evacuated from the gesture. The cargo arm lowers Silence to its side.

Then his communication slate pings.

It is a small sound — the standard freelancer-grade two-tone ping any operator carries on their belt — but it is loud in the room because the room has gone quiet, and because Kyle's NeoCortex is reading the slate's RF signature through electromagnetics before his ears have fully processed the audio, and the RF signature is not a message. It is a *receipt*. The slate is

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reporting that a transaction has cleared at the carrier level — a large transaction, six figures, the sort that does not arrive without the originator's banking handshake completing first — and Kyle reads the metadata in the half-second it takes the slate to chime: *Vásquez Holdings — final settlement — contract reference matches*. The money. The fee Hua's syndicate was owed, the money Kyle was accused of stealing, has just *arrived* in the account it was always supposed to arrive in. Late by exactly the length of one Lotus Syndicate punishment cycle. The client did what clients do when their courier disappears for a night and the original delivery confirms anyway: they processed the payment on the original schedule, the Syndicate's collection window closes, and Kyle is — by the books, by the receipt, by the same arithmetic Hua just admitted owing him — *exonerated*.

He does not smile. The discipline does not permit a smile. But somewhere in the NeoCortex's catalog something flips from *unresolved* to *resolved* and the reader, looking at his face, would not see it move; only Hua would, and only because she is the one looking for it.

She has heard the ping too.

She knows what the ping is. The Lotus Syndicate has its own slate channel for transactions of that size, and her own slate, somewhere on her person beneath the lacquered table, is registering the same handshake from the buyer's side. The hands she values are still flat on the table edge. They go very still. Then she says it — quietly, almost to herself, in the language she swears in when the situation has exceeded her ability to swear in any other language —

"操." A breath. Then louder, the syllables coming up through her chest the way pressure comes up through a damaged seal: "他妈的."

Cào. Tā mā de. The first one a single hard exhalation, the second a slower roll of contempt aimed at no one in the room except the woman who issued the punishment. She has just understood that she did not maim a thief. She maimed a man who completed his delivery. She owes him eighty-five thousand and an apology she will never be able to make and the rest of her career will be operated under both, and the receipt has just landed and she cannot un-land it.

Kyle waits for her to finish. He is patient. The discipline is patient. When she stops — when

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the breath goes out of the second curse and the silence comes back — he says it level, quiet, the kind of voice you use to close a door:

"Patience is a virtue."

He does not look back at her as he turns toward the chum barrel.

Then he turns toward the chum barrel.

The arm reaches in without instruction — the E.L.F. already knows where they are, has known since the maintenance lead seated behind his ear, has perhaps known longer than that — and lifts his hands out palms up, exactly as she placed them. The twine is in his jacket pocket, scavenged from a cable bundle on the service landing, and the terminal fingers work it through the cauterized wrist channels with the patient articulation of something that has, for the first time in eighteen years, a reason to be careful. The knot is functional. Not clean. The cargo arm lowers the loop over his head and the hands settle at the center of his chest, palms outward, dripping onto the flagstone, and the weight of them is the weight of something he already knew was true. He turns toward the surface. He does not look at Hua. Silence is in the cargo arm's grip. He has not let go of it. Behind him, at her own table, in her own room, surrounded by her own men, Hua is alive and she said it, and the debt is open-ended by his choice and runs on his clock and has no ceiling he is prepared to name yet, and that is the worst thing he could have done to her, and he did it, and he walks toward the door.



The freight grate opens onto rain.

Not weather — redistribution. The atmospheric processors are running their usual math three kilometers east and the Gray Zone gets what the Core sheds, and tonight what the Core sheds is a cold November downpour that hits the flagstone around the grate in flat percussion and does not stop. Kyle pulls himself through on his right forearm and the cargo arm's weight swings him sideways on the lip and he catches himself with his knee and stands. The bio-battery reads nine percent. The cargo arm's status strip has been dark for six minutes — brownout, the trickle cell finally gone, the E.L.F. drawing on his own reserves

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to keep the terminal fingers closed around Silence, which is a cost he did not negotiate and cannot renegotiate at nine percent. He does not ask it to stop. He does not ask anything. He starts walking north.

The hands knock against his sternum with each step. Palms outward, dripping now with rainwater mixed with chum barrel residue, the twine doing its functional work, the knot holding. The NeoCortex timestamps his pace at ninety-four steps per minute, which is the pace the facility calibrated as sustainable-while-injured, the pace that does not read as flight and does not read as incapacity, the pace that gets you four blocks without anyone calculating what you are. He passes the first block. The rain comes down the same way it came down before the Depot, before the sluice, before the table, indifferent to the debt he just opened and the name still sitting in the room behind him. The second block. The cargo arm drags at the coupling. Silence is still in the borrowed grip, the saya wet and dark in the rain. The blade was always the point. *The blade is the point.* He is still holding it. He keeps walking.

Two blocks from the kiosk his mouth opens.

I will visit you again. His own voice, his own registers, the cadence slightly long — reading a sentence it has not spoken before. He does not stop walking. Ninety-four steps per minute, exact, the pace stays exact because the pace is the only variable he controls right now and he is going to control it. He counts two steps. Four. Then he asks it flat, his own voice, the question he has been holding since the maintenance lead seated behind his ear eighteen hours ago by the count he is keeping: *What are you called.*

The rain comes down. The pause that follows is not hesitation. It is *rummaging*. Kyle feels it in the back of his skull, behind the auditory contact behind his left ear — a quiet, methodical search through indices the entity does not have, looking for something the entity does not own. First the cybernetic strata: the NeoCortex catalog, the dorsal port row's metadata, the firmware-side fragments the maintenance lead picked up during transfer. The search finds nothing usable. The entity does not have a *name*. The entity has not been called anything in eighteen years because there has been no one to call it anything. It needs a label, and the place it has decided to look for one is *deeper*.

Kyle feels the search cross from cybernetic into organic. It is not painful. It is more invasive than painful. The entity is reading the parts of him that are *meat* — the hippocampal

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indexing, the long-storage memory tissue, the places his cybernetics do not normally route through and his peers do not know how to access. He feels it sift, polite and patient, the way a librarian sifts a card catalog they have not been given permission to read. Childhood. Iowa. Pre-facility. A county fair when he was six years old, his grandfather's hand on his shoulder, a small wooden booth at the back of the livestock pavilion where a man Kyle never saw worked the strings of two carved figures from below the curtain. He had watched for twenty minutes. He had not understood, at six, that the figures were not alive — and then he had understood, because the man's hand had come up briefly into view to adjust a tangled string, and the strings had become visible, and the magic had not been ruined; the magic had been *named*. The man behind the booth, his grandfather had told him in the walk back to the car, was a *puppeteer*. The word had landed in Kyle the way certain words land in children — load-bearing, archived without filing, carried for forty years against an event that would never come.

The entity finds the word. Kyle feels it find the word. It does not take the word — Kyle still has the memory, the booth, the grandfather, the strings — but it *copies* the word, the way you copy a name out of a contact list, and the entity now has a label.

Then his mouth answers itself: *Puppeteer*.

The cadence is slightly long, the syllables reading a sentence the body has not spoken before — but the word is *his*, in the most specific sense the chapter has produced. He gave the entity the name it just used on him. He gave it forty years ago in the walk back from a county fair he had forgotten he remembered. And then the mouth is his again and he files the name in the same place he filed the salvage glyph and the EMT-spec band model and the specific sound of the cleaver going down twice, and he keeps walking, and the arithmetic resolves in the dry register the NeoCortex reserves for catalog work: the cargo arm is empty hardware. Has been since the junction box on the maintenance landing. The E.L.F. is resident in him — has been since the contact seated, will leave when Puppeteer chooses to leave, will return on Puppeteer's schedule. He has no leverage. He does not stop walking. The AutoDoc kiosk is at the corner of Ashland and Whiting and it is still where it was this morning and that is the only fact he needs right now.

The kiosk reads the necklace. He does not know how. He keyed in with his chin and the panel registered the biometric and then the panel registered something else — the hands at

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his sternum, the twine, the EMT-spec bands, the tissue window still open — and the AutoDoc opened without requiring him to explain. The surgical arms are the same surgical arms they always are: articulated, precise, indifferent in the specific way of machines that have no stake in what they are repairing. They lift him onto the table with the same gentle math they use on everyone and he lets them. They take the necklace. They take the cargo arm — the coupling releases at the shoulder and the arm goes to the instrument tray and does not move, the status strip dark, shell only — and they slide Silence out of the borrowed grip with the careful, automated reverence machines have for swords and lay it on the side tray and it is there, it is on the tray, it is four feet from his left hand which is about to exist again. The antibiotic pump is already running. The analgesic arrives from the kiosk's own dispensary in a dose large enough to mute the night and he feels it go in and the night begins to mute and as it mutes the NeoCortex feed produces a glyph in the not-factory pattern, the pattern Puppeteer has been signing in, three syllables in old Axiom signage, and Kyle reads it as the anesthesia takes him under: *we are not done*. The AutoDoc's status light goes green. The rain comes down outside the kiosk. Silence is on the side tray. The sentence sits somewhere he cannot easily delete, patient and old, the same frequency as something that has been in the ferrocrete longer than the facility's survey teams were willing to go.



He wakes at 0344 by the kiosk's analog clock — the digital readout at the upper bezel says the same number, the analog hand confirms it without commentary, the AutoDoc has its own reasons for keeping the redundancy. The hands are at the ends of his arms. They are pink in the bracelet pattern at the wrists where the cauterizer band held tissue against tissue while the surgical arms did the work, the seam clean, the perfusion finding its rhythm. He flexes the right hand. The fingers move. He flexes the left. Same. The grip is at sixty percent of baseline, which is what he expected and what the AutoDoc's discharge summary confirms in a single line of text he does not bother to read in full. Silence is on the side tray. The cargo arm is on the instrument tray, separate, shell-dark. He takes the blade. He leaves the cargo arm.

Take what is yours. The borrowed limb is not yours. It was a tool. The tool is finished.

The kiosk lets him out into the rain. Ashland and Whiting at 0347 is empty in the way that

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intersection gets at this hour — the recycler exhaust steaming off the corner stack, the streetlight on the west side flickering at the rate it has been flickering for two years, a single Vultures truck idling at the far curb, lights off, the driver behind the wheel reading something on a handset and not looking up as Kyle passes. Kyle does not look at the truck either. The Vultures and Kyle have an arrangement now. The arrangement is that they are aware of each other and neither of them has yet decided what to do about it. The arrangement may stay this way for a long time. He keeps walking.

The distance from Ashland-and-Whiting to The Pivot is one point two kilometers. Kyle walks it in twenty-three minutes, which is twice baseline. The shoulder catches at every step. The reattached fingers send small probing signals up the wrist that the NeoCortex catalogues and does not act on. The blade rides at his right hip in the friction sheath because the back-carry is not available tonight. The rain comes down, redistributed, deliberate, the way it always comes down. He does not count the blocks. He does not count the steps. He has done enough counting tonight.

The body is going to shake in approximately seven minutes. Be inside before then.

The Pivot's lobby door reads his biometric and admits him without requiring the second factor; the lock has not asked for the second factor in three years and Kyle has not pressed the building's manager on the slack because the slack works in his favor. The stairwell is the stairwell. He climbs. The third step from the top has the loose riser that has been loose since 2198 and produces the same small sound it always produces under his weight, and Kyle's weight on it produces it correctly, and that is apparently enough.

The door to 2E opens before he reaches the landing.

Pixel in pajamas, the same as last time — bare feet on the hall's cold composite, the music inside the unit cut the moment she heard the stair, her hair loose, the crease on her left cheek from the pillow she has just left, the oversized sweater traded for a long-sleeve thermal that covers the same arms with the same compulsive thoroughness. She takes one look at him — the blade at his hip instead of his back, the pink bracelet visible at his cuffs where the leather rides up, the way he is standing — and her hand goes to her mouth and stays there.

"Thank god you're all right." The words come out small and wet, pressed through her

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fingers. Then: *"Sable said she'd take her somewhere safe."*

Kyle stops at the top of the stairs. He does not know how Pixel knows about Sable taking the doctor. Then he does know — Sable would have routed a message, because Sable routes messages, because Pixel was in the middle of the operational loop in the kitchen scene at the half-hour mark and Sable does not leave loose ends with operators she has decided to trust. He files the implication. He has not decided yet what it means that Sable has decided to trust Pixel. He suspects it means more than he is prepared to process tonight.

Pixel takes one step into the hall.

Then another. She is approaching him the way you approach a fence-pinned animal — slow, with the angle adjusted, no quick movement — and Kyle understands, in the time it takes her to cover the two meters between them, that she is going to touch him. He has time to step back. He has time to put up his right hand in the small gesture that has worked for four years to indicate *not now*. He does not step back. He does not put up the hand. His arms are very heavy and the AutoDoc's analgesic has not fully cleared and the night has been long in the way nights become long when the arithmetic is not complicated only costly, and he is so tired he cannot remember what he is supposed to be doing instead of letting her come.

She takes his hands.

Both at once. Both wrists, in the pattern the AutoDoc left there — bracelet to bracelet, palm up, the way you take something fragile that has just been put back together. Her hands are the same hands they always are: precise, minor scarring, the faint outline of the diagnostic port at the left wrist base where she has been calibrating his hardware for the last three years. The temperature differential is the part Kyle is not prepared for. Her hands are warm. The pink seam at his wrists is warm too — perfusion still finding its rhythm — but in a different register, a register that does not yet feel like *his*. Her warmth and his warmth meet at the bracelet line, and the part of his brain that has spent four years filing Pixel under *neighbor / tool / quiet across the hall* loses the filing momentarily and does not produce a replacement.

Pull away. Pull away. The convention is the convention.

The convention is the convention. He almost does. The hand twitches in the direction of withdrawal — his right hand, the dominant one, the one that has been making this kind of

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decision for him since he was fifteen — and then the twitch resolves into stillness because he is too tired to complete it. He looks at her face. Her eyes are wet. Then they are not wet — they are leaking, openly, the kind of crying that is not performed for an audience because Pixel has never performed her crying for anyone, the kind of crying that happens when the body decides on its own that the moment requires it. The tears go down her cheeks and onto her jaw and from her jaw they fall.

The first one lands on the inside of his right wrist, on the pink seam.

Kyle has not been touched by another person without intent to harm or repair in approximately four months. He has not been touched in tenderness in approximately seven years. The hardware does not have a category for the temperature of a tear on a fresh surgical seam. It does not need one. The body knows. The body has always known. The body has been waiting, without his permission, to be given evidence that the touching was still possible.

A second tear lands. Then a third. They fall on both wrists now — she has not adjusted, she is just standing close enough that the geography works out — and each one sits warm on the pink for a second before the perfusion equalizes the temperature and the moisture wicks into the analgesic-thinned skin. Pixel's grip tightens on his wrists. Not hard. Carefully. The way you squeeze a thing you have been afraid of losing.

"Oh my god," she says, and the words are pressed through the same wet thickness as before, *"I'm sorry — does that hurt?"*

The pink seam aches under her fingers in the specific way a fresh reattachment aches — the nerves still negotiating, the subdermal mesh still re-pairing, the deep tissue lodging a small steady complaint about the cleaver work that the AutoDoc cannot fully suppress with surface analgesic. It hurts. It hurts in the way that means it is going to keep hurting for several days and possibly weeks, on a curve Pixel knows from her own clinical reading better than Kyle knows from his own body. She knows the answer to the question she just asked. She is asking it anyway because the asking is part of what is happening here.

Kyle finds his voice. The mask is the mask — calm, level, the voice he has practiced level for a long time — and he gives her the answer the convention requires.

"No," he says.

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It does. The lie is a small one and they both know he is telling it and neither of them is going to make a thing of it. Pixel nods, once, and the nod is acceptance — she will accept the lie because she understands what the lie is doing, which is making it possible for him to stand here in the hall at 0410 in the morning with her hands on his wrists and her tears on his bracelets without the convention shattering past either of their abilities to repair it. The discipline is the discipline. The discipline is also tonight what is letting him be here.

The convention between you is no longer purely tools-and-quiet. Note that. The catalogue has updated.

She lets go. Not all at once — she releases his wrists in two stages, the right first, then the left, then her hands fall to her sides and stay there. She steps back. She does not wipe her face. She does not perform composure. She just stands in the hall with her tears on her own cheeks and on his cuffs and lets the moment exist.

The music in 2E does not come back on. He has no memory of when it cut.

Kyle nods. The nod is the only thing he can produce that the convention will accept. Then he walks past her — careful, slow, the shoulder catching — and crosses the hall to 2F. The lock reads his biometric. The door admits him. He turns on no light. The room organizes itself out of the dark the way it always does: medkit by the door, notebook on the counter, the photograph of his mother on the windowsill facing the intersection because she would have wanted to see the street.

He sits on the edge of the bed. He does not remove the jacket. The shoulder is too sharp and the right hand at sixty percent grip is not capable of the small precise motions a jacket requires. The boots come off because the boots come off — that motion is automatic, has been automatic for nineteen years, will be automatic until the body stops. He does not remove anything else.

Silence comes off the right hip. He lays the friction sheath across the pillow first, then his torso, then settles the blade across his sternum in the saya the way Seo taught him to settle a sword for sleep when the night had gone wrong and the watch was still required. His left hand rests on the tsuka. His right hand rests on the saya. The pink seam at both wrists is visible against the dark of the leather, and Pixel's tears are still on the right cuff in two small dark spots that will be dry by morning and will not be visible to anyone who does not know

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to look.

Sleep. The arithmetic resolves in the morning. Sleep.

He lies down. The blade across his chest does not pin him; it composes him. The hardware logs the bio-battery at thirty-one percent, the lateral array's three thermal stress markers active, the reattached hands at sixty percent grip and recovering, the right shoulder at fifty-seven percent function and worsening, the cargo arm absent from inventory, Silence present, Puppeteer present-and-quiet, the analgesic finding its plateau. He closes his eyes.

Across the hall, the music does not come back on.

The rain comes down on the GLMZ the way it always comes down, redistributed, deliberate, falling on the only people who cannot move out of its way. Kyle sleeps. The blade sleeps with him. Pixel stands in her doorway for a long time, looking at the closed door across the hall, before she goes back inside her unit and shuts the door behind her without a sound.

The morning holds.